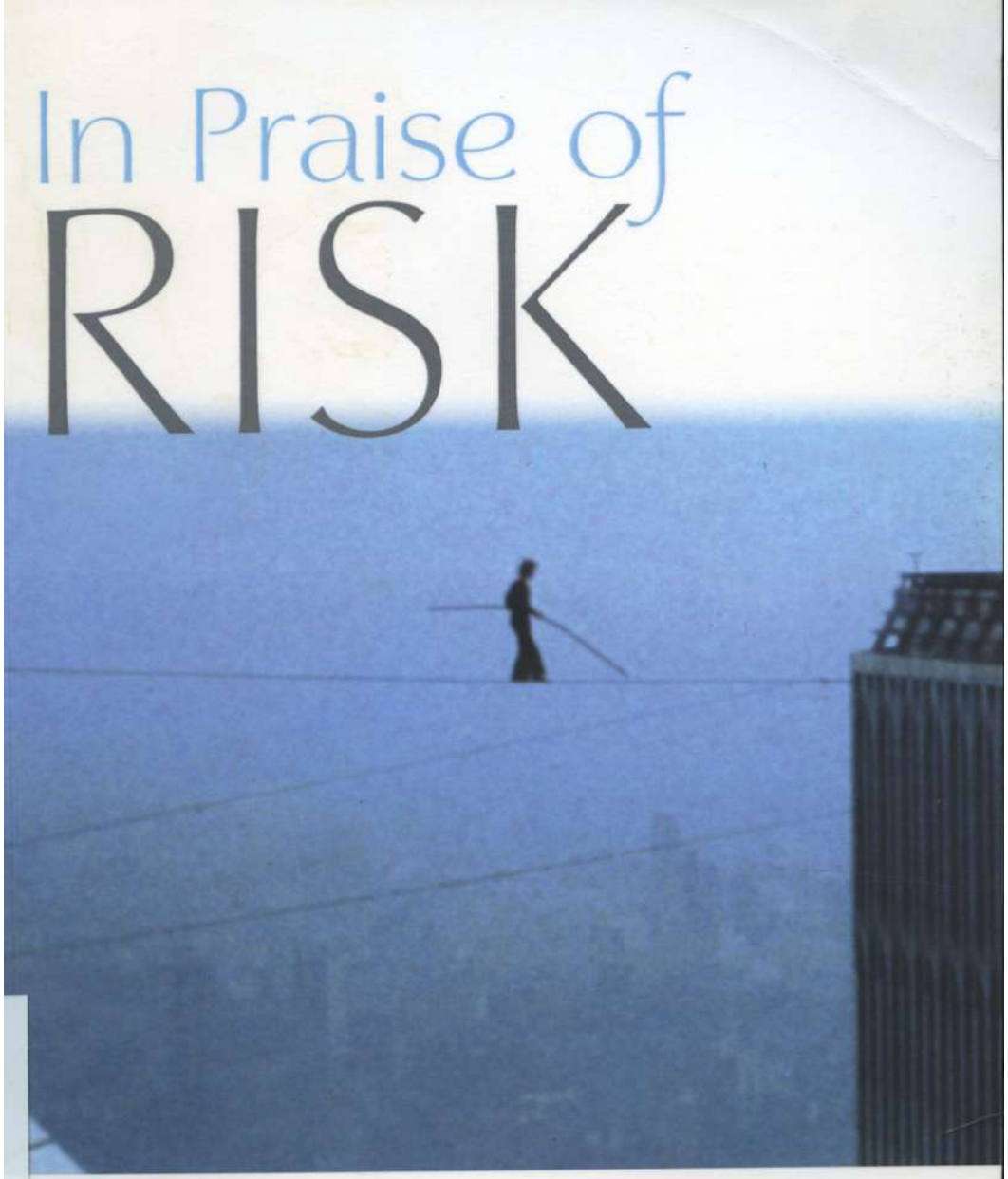
In Praise of RISK



Anne Dufourmantelle

TRANSLATED, WITH AN INTRODUCTION, BY Steven Miller

In Praise of Risk

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ANNE DUFOURMANTELLE

Translated by Steven Miller

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to Clara, Gabriel, and Maud

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TRANSLATOR'S INTRODUCTION: THE RISK OF READING

In July 2017, newspapers around the world ran prominent stories about the death of the philosopher and psychoanalyst Anne Dufourmantelle. Although Dufourmantelle was a profound writer who garnered widespread admiration for her many books, her death became a newsworthy event not so much for the value of her life's work but rather for the courageous act that led to it one summer afternoon near St. Tropez. Writing for the *New York Times*, Benoît Morenne and Megan Specia describe what happened:

> Ms. Dufourmantelle was on the beach when the weather began to change and the previously safe swimming area became treacherous. She saw two children who were in danger and leapt into the sea to help . . . before being caught in the rough surf.
>
> She was pulled unresponsive from the water by two other swimmers, and attempts to resuscitate her failed.[1]

For every newspaper that ran the story, however, it was not simply about a woman who risked her life to save two children. The story within this story, the hook that made it especially newsworthy, was about a philosopher who lived and died by her published words, who put theory into practice. In each and every newspaper that reported on Dufourmantelle's death, the headline touted the relationship between her philosophy and her final act. More than any other organization, *The New York Times* made this aspect of the narrative particularly explicit. Under the headline "Philosopher Who Praised Risk Died Trying to Save Children from Drowning," the article opens with a conclusion that is presented as a factual assertion: "A French philosopher and psychoanalyst, known for her work that praised living a life that embraced risk, died last week *as a result of following her own bold philosophy*" [my emphasis].[2] The book to which these statements most explicitly refer is the one that you hold in your hands, *In Praise of Risk* (originally published as *Éloge du risque* in 2011). The fact that the book now appears in translation is due, likely in no small measure, to the notoriety that it gained from the worldwide circulation of this reportage.

How fascinating and frightening to be able to read the very book that set the stage for its author's death. How awe-inspiring and refreshing to read the work of a philosopher whose words are more than empty words, jargon, or obscurantism—a philosopher who does not just learn but manifestly knows how to die.

Dufourmantelle appears to embody what Simon Critchley calls "the ideal of the philosophical death."[3] The news of her death is the good news that the ideal might become real—that, if all too briefly, the truth walked among us, and she was a woman. Let us now praise dead philosophers. Thanks to the renown of Dufourmantelle's courage, a wider public will have the opportunity to discover her essayistic, provocative, and beautiful prose. All of this said, however, I will use the opportunity of this introduction to dispel the expectations raised by the assumption that the risk named in Dufourmantelle's title is the same as the risk whereby she jeopardized and ultimately lost her own life.

Risk is never neutral. It is always an object of praise or blame, an occasion for celebration or lamentation. Dufourmantelle thus opens her reflections on risk not with a proposition (subject to logico-grammatical analysis) but rather an unconjugated infinitive phrase; and what she celebrates about this phrase is not its truth but its beauty. "To risk one's life [*risquer sa vie*]" she extols, "is among the most beautiful expressions in our language." The praise of risk, then, begins with the language that upholds the place of risk in the world. And what's beautiful about this language is the economy with which it encapsulates the symbolic economy of risk society, without forgetting the dimension of risk that escapes its ritualized system of exchange. On the one hand, the expression evokes the Hobbesian paradigm in which the quiet and routine of everyday life are nothing but the absence of risk, the war of all against all held at bay, a fragile episode of calm purchased at the price of unending calculation, precaution, and surveillance.[4] To take a risk, according this this paradigm, is to abandon peace for war, coverage for exposure, the inside for the outside, illusion for reality, the shore for the rough sea, a comfortable life for a beautiful death. And praise would be the symbolic recognition ritually conferred on the brave individuals who abandon their protected existence within the social order in order to confront the abiding evils that threaten it. It's almost impossible, in fact, to separate the expression, *to risk one's life*, from the rituals of praise that belong to the theater of sacrifice.[5] On the other hand, the same expression says none of this. As if forever suspended in mid-thought, it is precisely the type of enigmatic infinitive phrase, without determinate subject or object, whereby an analyst might intervene during a session. Likewise,

the analyst in Dufourmantelle declines to predicate the phrase any further. Where a scene of sacrifice would seem about to open up, she stays silent; or rather, she upholds the constitutive understatement of the phrase itself as the occasion for a question—the question that orients her exploration throughout the book. "How not to wonder," she asks, "what becomes of a culture when it can no longer think about risk except as a heroic act, pure madness, deviant conduct? . . . *How is it possible, as a living being, to think risk in terms of life rather than death?*" [my emphasis]. The same expression, then, participates in the ancient economy of sacrifice, giving praise where praise is due, but it also offers praise that could never be earned, extoling the risk that life is, all to itself, before it has ever been exposed to danger, perhaps before it has been exposed to death.

Dufourmantelle's project is to discover—in a searching and experimental combination of philosophical reflection and psychoanalytic case histories—whether such a "before" is even thinkable. Accordingly, the horizon that orients her approach to risk is not death and sacrifice, devotion and heroism, but rather what she calls not dying [*ne pas mourir*], once again relying on an enigmatic infinitive that invites incompatible readings.[6] "I interrogate risk in a manner that does not permit its evaluation or its elimination, within the horizon of: not dying." There is undoubtedly something provocative about such an approach, which flies directly in the face of the melancholy certainty that the greatest risk to life would be its end. Surprisingly, perhaps, her refusal to understand (or deplore or cherish) life in light of potential loss recalls (the obvious differences of style and culture aside) Arakawa and Gins's matter-of-fact declaration that "we have decided not to die."[7]

Each journalistic account of Dufourmantelle's death takes the opportunity, in her name, to reproduce the very paradigm of risk that she explicitly seeks to displace. The journalists who reported on her death, it would seem, did not pause actually to read further than the title of her book and thereby to take the risk of muddling their own narrative. The idea that made Dufourmantelle's death a good story—that she died young by putting her theory of risk into practice—entails an unacknowledged betrayal of her actual ideas about risk. Posthumously, in homage to her often playful catalogue (for example, dependency, suspense, passion, breaking up, leaving the family, solitude, variation, and the unknown), we might add the risk of reading.

Although the *New York Times* report of Dufourmantelle's death identifies her as a "philosopher and psychoanalyst," it goes on to presume, without noticeable justification, that she died solely as a philosopher. Would

her heroic action be less heroic, or her story less of a story, or her philosophy less philosophical, if she died as a psychoanalyst? Is the presumption that a psychoanalyst wouldn't have a philosophy to give meaning to her death? Or that psychoanalytic theory, unlike philosophy, does not uphold an ideal or entail any precepts that a person would "follow" to the grave? In order to begin reading this book (and thinking about the singular death of its author), then, it is also important to remember that, in many of Dufourmantelle's books, but particularly in this book, fragments of clinical case histories regularly cut through her philosophical reflections. Because the majority of the book's fifty short chapters, each on a distinct type of risk, include clinical material, the reader—or at least the philosophically inclined reader—might conclude that Dufourmantelle provides these cases as examples of risk. This would be a conclusion, however, that disregards the uniqueness of the genre of the psychoanalytic case history: that it traces the origin of a patient's symptom or disturbance not to a generalizable cause (which will apply in every case) but rather to a singular history, the idiom of an irreplaceable body. In order to insist on the distinction between case and example, perhaps, Dufourmantelle inserts the histories and leaves them suspended without lengthy explanation of them. She resists any discourse that would soften their disruptive force or ease the transition between philosophy and analytic experience. They function, in a sense, like punctuations of the analytic session, offered in an affirmative and contestatory spirit, at odds with the onrush of speech. In other words, she refuses to do what journalism did with her case: to make these patients into so many faces of risk, to sacrifice their lives (or their deaths) for the glory of the concept and the intelligibility of her own discourse.

Dufourmantelle speaks a language that interrupts itself. Turning to case histories, or fragments thereof, all cut short, she cuts herself off; she acts as an analyst in relation to her own philosophical discourse. Among the most consequential and fascinating—albeit unthematized—aspects of this book, in fact, is the unique way in which it stages the psychoanalytic act and the position of the analyst. Most likely, no aspect of psychoanalysis is more broadly misunderstood, and infrequently theorized, than the role of the analyst herself in the process of the analytic cure. Typically, analysts are judged (by patients and fellow analysts alike) in terms of the opposition between absence and presence, withdrawal and empathy. But Dufourmantelle's brief clinical narratives show us how much more complex and unforeseeable the position of the analyst always is in practice. The often maligned silence of the analyst, she observes, is an inherently

paradoxical mode of engagement: *"The silence of the analyst opens a suspense. It is not a nonresponse or a nonreception; it is an engagement with the nonresolution of an act, an invitation to take further risks, to hold unbearable contradictions within oneself and bring them alive."* In other words, the analyst does not occupy the position of what Jacques Lacan called the "the subject supposed to know" (*le sujet supposé savoir*).[8] In fact, as Freud makes perfectly clear in his case histories, the elementary analytic act is to suppose that the *patient* knows everything of any importance to interpret her own symptoms. The first thing that the analyst does is to disallow categorically the patient's frequent claims that she is paralyzed, does not know, or has nothing to say. In *Studies in Hysteria*, for example, the text in which Freud describes his first experiences with psychoanalysis per se, which led him to abandon hypnosis as a therapeutic method, the analyst writes: "Eventually I grew so confident that, if patients answered, 'I see nothing' or 'nothing occurred to me,' I could dismiss this as an impossibility and could assure them that they had certainly become aware of what was wanted but had refused to believe that that was so and had rejected it."[9] This unshakeable confidence on the analyst's part in the simple fact that there is something to know is what, in turn, makes it possible for each patient to take the risk of speech, to assume what Freud called a "moral courage." Often, however, as Freud himself learned in the course of his long practice as a psychoanalyst, and as the history of psychoanalysis after Freud has decisively confirmed, such courage requires more than speech. Although the medium of psychoanalytic work is language, the silence of the psychoanalyst also implies a recognition that not all knowledge can be spoken, especially knowledge of experiences that the subject inherits from her own infancy or even from the unconscious of previous generations. Dufourmantelle, in her case histories, privileges the turning points at which the analytic experience carries the patient and the analyst alike up to the limits of the speakable. Psychoanalysis, she shows, is more than a process of anamnesis that helps the patient to reach an ethical transformation. Beyond anamnesis, in order for access to unconscious knowledge to become possible, it also requires the patient to transform the structure of her life radically, to begin anew, and to discover new resources of expression. Accordingly, moments arise when, in order to welcome such transformations and the risks that they entail, the analyst improvises, breaks from routine, and transforms the parameters of her work with the patient, often to her own great surprise.

Each of Dufourmantelle's case histories depicts a patient who risks his or her life in order to make room for never before acknowledged or articulated experiences, fragments of life never before lived. The first case

history in *In Praise of Risk*, which figures in the second chapter, "Eurydice Saved," is printed in italics, like all the others in the book, and appears to be inserted between paragraphs. It tells of a woman who, for as long as she can remember, presumed that she would die at age thirty. She lived her life in the past tense, as if it had already come full circle: *"And since she had kept death in her sights for thirty years, her life came to resemble the yellowed photographs that one looks at like a document from another age; it had always been thought in the past tense, starting from that moment of annulment that should be her death."* She finds an analyst who gains her trust because he listens without trying to convince her, as many others had done, that she probably wouldn't really die when or how she anticipated. After a handful of sessions, however, she arrives at this analyst's building only to discover that he had died and no one told her the news. This contretemps, especially because it involves the death of an analyst, raises difficult questions about the intersubjective status of death—whether it is simply a matter of loss and disappearance, passively undergone, or whether, even when not a suicide, it always has the force of an act. For this specific patient, at least, still at an early phase of her analysis, the death of her analyst, has the effect of an intervention: *"In the street, she knew that death had come to pass, that it took someone else."* At first, it might seem that this analyst died *for* his patient; that he took *her* death upon himself so that she might live. This is not entirely mistaken (although, strictly speaking, as Heidegger asserted, it is not possible to take anyone's death away from them). In part, what her analyst's death enables this woman to confront is the fact that death is never simply one's own. His death, precisely because it is absolutely singular, like all deaths, very well might have been hers. For the same reason, however, his death could not have been an act of devotion, a heroic sacrifice on her behalf: *"In her place? No, not even. It was just that she would no longer be there at the appointed time."* At her own death, too, she would arrive too late. This unexpected but hardly unusual missed encounter reveals that there is not, and never was, any position from which she (or anyone else) could bear witness to her own death and thereby regard her life as a thing of the past. Rather than saving her from death, this event leaves her to inherit her ongoing life for the first time. "It was like an accident, a car wreck from which she was miraculously spared. She should pay attention to this life *not so much given back but abruptly given to her*" (my emphasis).

In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, Freud writes that all life strives unto death. But, he adds, the goal of this striving resides in the ancient past. The death drive is regressive. Rather than venture toward an unpredictable end, it seeks the extinction of a time before life emerged. Dufourmantelle,

in turn, invites us to consider the complexity of this regressive movement. Her patients bear witness again and again that emergence of life is never a simple, punctiform event. Even at the very beginning, in order to survive, life must hold not only death but also itself in abeyance; it remains virtual. Rather than spiraling back toward extinction, then, the death drive would regress from the actual to the virtual; it would constrain the subject to revisit the very conditions of their survival. In another case, involving a man who lost his wife and his memory in a car accident, Dufourmantelle gives us a sense for how the psychoanalytic clinic of brain damage might unfold: *He had forgotten his name, his life. His memory was totaled along with his car in an accident that killed the wife whom he loved (so he was told).* What does psychoanalysis have to offer such a patient without access to his own past, who has lost any relationship to his own archive? What is psychoanalysis if not a process of anamnesis?[10]

> *The analysis would last a few years. The memories never came back. But something, out of oblivion, did come. Came back within the very time of what should be called a new life. An other love, an other apartment, different tastes, and a profession that happened almost by chance. Thanks to a passion for scuba diving in which it turned out that he was especially gifted, he became a deep sea diving instructor. There couldn't be a more precise metaphor for what he gave up looking for in himself—the traces, the vestiges, the unexploited, and unfindable resources of what had constituted what is commonly called an identity. What came back, then, was the sensation of having a body. His own—that his, a body that also came from the past, made of images and fears, hesitations, sensitivities, and urges that came from beyond him; and little by little this body took its place within him like a transplanted heart, not entirely foreign and not yet himself. In a sense, forgetting became his friend—a risk run, yes, like a risky hand in poker that you play anyway, to see what happens.*

Even a subject without a single memory left, without any recognition of his own life or his loves, is not entirely cut off from his past or his childhood. Dufourmantelle supposes that her patient has a knowledge—both *savoir* and *savoir-faire*— of childhood that isn't identified with memories and that doesn't belong to the past. Whereas, before the accident, this man had been a landscape architect, the experience of radical oblivion allowed him to discover a talent and a passion for deep sea diving, and, along with this profession, a childhood before the formation of childhood memories, the unspoken and uncanny history of a singular body, which Dufourmantelle sometimes calls the "uterine body." In such a case, psychoanalysis does not, and indeed cannot, reconstruct memories that have been utterly destroyed.

Instead, as Dufourmantelle suggests, it offers the patient an opening to forget about who he used to be and to build a new life. But this new life doesn't simply impose a radical cut, an absolute break of the future from the past; it entails the risk of giving life, for the first time, to the vestiges of an immemorial past, perhaps nothing more substantial than the "sensation of a having a body." Rather than open toward death, the end of life, risk opens toward the body, which, for Dufourmantelle, is not so much synonymous with life, but rather constitutes a division within life, a life before life, or an unclaimed identity.

This book opens with a case that pivots on the sudden death of the analyst, then, in order to foreground the precipitation that, at times, characterizes the analytic act, the decision to alter the parameters of the work, without forewarning, especially when the framework of psychoanalysis itself becomes an obstacle to knowledge. There is undoubtedly something at least potentially sadistic about such unexplained shifts, since there is no guarantee, in advance, that they will lead anywhere. In the moment, they entail the risk of merely subjecting the patient to the pointless whims of the analyst. At the same time, as Dufourmantelle shows us again and again, the analyst's ability to surprise herself in the act, to proceed without foreknowledge entails a radical trust in the unknown, the fragments of experience that remain repressed because they have never been spoken. "*One day,*" she begins another case history, "*I discovered a different way of working in analysis that had already lasted three years.*" In response to the patient's frequent inability to get to her second session each week, the analyst offers that both of her sessions should be scheduled on the same day: first a session at the usual time, then a break, and then the second session. What the patient most appreciated about this arrangement, much to her own surprise, was the break between her two sessions. This delimited space of time, it turned out, opened an empty frame in which the uncanny figure of a lost child could appear: "*Several dreams appeared that revolved around the figure of a child whom she lost in a crowd or cared for so poorly that it died. Intrigued by the insistence of this figure (the patient had no children yet), I will ask her about her family genealogy and the order of births. Had a child been 'forgotten'? What absence of a tomb haunted the nights of this young woman?*" When another patient declares that his money troubles make it necessary for him to stop coming to analysis, Dufourmantelle offers him the chance to continue at no cost until his financial situation improved: "*Never had I proposed such a radical solution to one of my patients and God knows many of them were in more precarious situations than his. But I felt that he was on the edge . . .*" In response to this act of trust, which evokes something in him beyond words,

the patient writes and brings pages from a new novel to each session. To borrow the words of Serge André: writing begins where psychoanalysis ends (albeit in the midst of analysis).[11] Later, Dufourmantelle adds, this patient would decide to become an analyst himself. Finally, in the analysis of a young and highly successful vascular surgeon who presented with "the symptoms of recalcitrant melancholy, recalcitrant to life and to death," she surprises herself again: "*And yet, one day I suggested that she write something. Rarely, if ever, did I make such a demand: to solicit a text. But I was at a loss, incapable of helping this woman without any consciousness of her femininity, her fragility, her exceptional intelligence, and without any desire other than to operate (especially life-saving surgeries)—everything else expunged from the chessboard of her life.*" The patient's response to this demand—as much to its object as to the departure from routine that it represented—is remarkable. Writing becomes the place for the desire that has no place in her life:

> Her writings were akin to molten lava. Full of a vertiginous consciousness of the most intimate folds of the feminine heart. One might have believed that she spent her life in the waiting room of an analyst, a gynecologist, and a highly accomplished sociologist. Short sentences, vitriolic, devoid of pathos. She didn't comment on her own pages; as first, she resisted talking about them or offering associations, as if it was an other woman who expressed herself in them. The analyst's office became the place for this deposition and little by little, affects began to intervene, like isolated blocks drifting on the surface of a precisely regulated discourse. Then came her dreams. Seething, very somber, full of murder and madness, amphitheaters rife with assassins, rapists, prowlers, open hearts, and eviscerated bellies. Desire here is nothing but writing. Diffracted in the violence of these imagined, written destinies, it begins to be able to begin to be said; and no one can say whether the splitting that shelters such passion will one day have another theater than these proffered pages, which absolutely deserve to be published without any further commentary. What does it mean for an analyst to be the keeper and thus temporarily the witness to this chain of unchained words, to such a fulgurant writing of desire?

Cases such as this one, along with the many others that Dufourmantelle brings forth in this book, remind us that the unconscious comprises more than memory; that, precisely because it entails infantile experience, it encompasses more than the past, more than lived experience. This surplus is libidinal, not cerebral (pace Malabou). Dufourmantelle reminds us that sexuality itself is older than the subject, that the persistence of the drive

ultimately opens the subject to the singular history of her unlived experiences. This is the aspect of the unconscious that Freud encounters in the form of the repetition compulsion, that Walter Benjamin brings to our attention in "On Some Motifs in Baudelaire," with the distinction between *Erlebnis* (lived experience) and *Erfahrung* (unlived experience), and that Lacan formalizes with the claim that it is structured like a language.[12] Accordingly, it is this aspect of the unconscious that compels analysts and patients alike to go beyond the work of anamnesis, to risk calling its own framework into question, to supplement speech with writing and artistic production, explicitly to solicit the future. Notably, Freud encapsulated the process of analysis in three unconjugated infinitive verbs: *erinnern*, *widerholen*, and *durcharbeiten* (remembering, repeating, and working through), as if to indicate that the progress of analysis opens toward an encounter with something that does not align with the order to grammatical predication. Even Freud's well-known archeological metaphors hinge on the factor of surprise, the potential for an encounter with a past older (or newer) than the past: "Our insight into this early, pre-Oedipus, phase in girls comes to us as a surprise, like the discovery, in another field, of the Minoan-Mycenean civilization behind the civilization of Greece."[13] Dufourmantelle thus highlights the risk, the potential for transformative surprise, that structures this archeological enterprise. Her radical departures from routine—because they display an immense confidence, not so much in the analyst's own abilities, but rather in the future—offer patients a chance to make room in their lives for what, in the unconscious, remains incompatible with the patterns of lived experience.

There is a quality of Dufourmantelle's writing that might be called lyrical because it is always restless, slightly out of joint; it upholds the disjunction between saying and knowing, stages the wandering of a voice at odds with language. The singularity of her style heeds a demand that, in many of the book's philosophical fragments, is articulated as the demand to get ahead of oneself. At one point, Dufourmantelle contends that this demand is nothing other than freedom: "Does freedom teach us anything? Perhaps not. It demands that we risk our desire as if it were something infinitely precious, a unique event, an imperious voice; that, in sum, we go out in front of ourselves [*aller . . . en devant de soi*], go where we didn't know we are, where something unknown to us yet speaks of us and convokes us. Freedom is a convocation." And this convocation appears in various guises throughout the book. Among Dufourmantelle's pivotal concepts, which harkens back to her first book, *La vocation prophétique de la philosophie* (Éditions du Cerf, 1998), for example, is that of "intimate prophecy." It is

introduced early in her reflections, in connection with her determination of risk as not dying: "To risk one's life is first, perhaps, not dying. Dying in the midst of our lives, in every form of renunciation, the blankness of depression, sacrifice. To risk one's life at decisive moments of our existence is an act that pushes ahead of us on the basis of a still unknown knowledge [*un acte qui nous devance à partir d'un savoir encore inconnu de nous*], like an intimate prophecy; it is a moment of conversion." Elsewhere, this prophetic haste or urgency becomes the basis for a revaluation of the category of the "visionary," to artistic creation, and ultimately to the singular intelligibility of the unconscious:

> We are afraid of our own capacity to perceive, of the "visionary" in us, of what is commonly called intuition—that is, a knowledge you have in advance of yourself [*un savoir en avance de soi*]; a knowledge from which one would rather deliver oneself even before it can be clearly formulated. Retroactively, our gestures, our dreams, our slips of the tongue, and our bungled actions reveal to us, like prophetic utterances, this capacity for intelligible perception much vaster than the ego. Artistic creation is always at grips with the apparatus out ahead of you [*ce dispositif logé en avant de soi*] that informs you, somehow unbeknownst to you, and that unfolds on the canvas, in the score, or on the page even before consciousness takes notice.

Artistic creation, in other words, teaches us that we see not with our eyes but with the drive that inhabits us. The drive, rather than the senses, is what gives access to objects that are not yet objects, that do not yet figure among the world of perceptible things; it entails a movement not just beyond the pleasure principle, but also beyond the reality principle—and beyond the morality of adaptation that it implies.[14] In accordance with such reflections, Dufourmantelle arrives at the hypothesis that the unconscious itself is incompatible with consciousness, not because it harbors unwanted knowledge, but rather because it is turned toward the future:

> Why at certain moments of our lives are we in advance of ourselves? I would like to be able to think the psychic reserve in us whereby we gain access to the future beyond the narrow confines of our consciousness, our class, our education, our fears, and our inability to confront alterity. This ability would be—such is, at least, the hypothesis that I am developing here—a sort of unconscious turned toward the future, toward the promise, toward what portends itself. What derails neurosis—the "always already known," the "been there done that"—is the possibility within us of opening to something hitherto unsuspected, to a different

time . . . It's the hidden face of this "knowledge without knowledge" that can be expressed collectively in revolts, revolutions, movements of anticipation or the avant-garde that announce a step beyond the present time or generalized servitude, bringing about a secondary "collective consciousness."

The risk *par excellence*, for Dufourmantelle, is not that of death or loss of life; it is the risk of opening to something hidden or, to use her privileged word, something "intimate," such as an "intimate prophecy" or an "intimate time." Guided by the testimony of her patients, Dufourmantelle finds that this "intimate" dimension of life unexpectedly comes into play at moments when the possibility of death is set aside.

The photograph on the cover of this book shows the tiny figure of Philippe Petit in the midst of his notorious walk, early in the morning of August 7, 1974, on a high wire rigged between the recently built towers of the World Trade Center in New York City. The high-wire artist, appropriately enough, is among the central figures of risk to which Dufourmantelle often returns in the course of her reflections. In common parlance, as well, this figure is shorthand for the narrowest possible margin between life and death, success and failure. There is no more explicit and fascinating figure for the omnipresence of disaster, it would seem. And yet, the emblematic image of the high-wire walker does not represent him off balance, teetering above the void, but rather utterly focused out on the wire. Accordingly, for Dufourmantelle, the moment that encapsulates the entire art of high-wire walking is when the artist holds still on the wire. Precisely because this is the moment of greatest risk, standing becomes a distinct event, disjoined from sequence or succession. The high-wire artist risks death, then, not to flaunt his own survival or invulnerability, but rather, as Dufourmantelle writes, to open toward an "intimate time," a risk that does not belong to the time of the performance but to the singular history of the artist's body:

> The high-wire artist risks falling, most of all when he holds still, when he attempts to stand in place, almost without moving a muscle. He must restrain the very momentum that gives him stability. As a high-wire artist, he prefers to attempt this miracle of suspense upon the wire. It might be said that he is waiting—but that is not what is happening. Suspension is not the arrested time that comes *before* something else happens; it is the event itself, the passage into the intimate time where, in reality, the decision has already been made but no one knows it yet.

At the center of Petit's own poetic treatise on funambulism is a chapter entitled, precisely, "The Quest for Immobility," which begins:

> This [the quest for immobility] is the mystery of the rope dance. The essence, the secret. Time plays no part in achieving it.
>
> Or perhaps I should say "in approaching it."
>
> To approach it, the high-wire walker turns himself into an alchemist. Again and again, he attempts it along the wire, but without ever entering the Domain of Immobility . . .
>
> The feeling of a second of immobility—if the wire grants it to you—is an intimate happiness.[15]

The word translated into English as "intimate" in both of these texts on the high wire, in French, is *intime*—a quietly pivotal word throughout Dufourmantelle's book. She asks, for example: "How is it possible, as a living being, to think risk in terms of life rather than death? At the instant of decision, risk calls into question our intimate relationship with time [*notre rapport intime au temps*]. It is a combat with an adversary whom we never identify, a desire that we would never know, a love whose face we would never see, a pure event." Intimacy rather than death, for Dufourmantelle, is what defines risk. Whereas in contemporary usage the word "intimate" primarily designates the close (often sexual) relationship between adults, and this sense of the word has recently been aligned with the risk of psychoanalytic thinking in the work of Tim Dean,[16] the translation from French must rely on the survival of an older sense of the term (*OED*: "inmost, most inward, deep-seated; hence, pertaining to or connected with the inmost nature or fundamental character of a thing; essential; intrinsic"), according to which the intimate refers to a radical or hyperbolic interiority, more inward than the self or the heart, the heart of hearts (or what, in French, is called the *for intérieur*). At this inner limit, for Dufourmantelle, intimacy is also more foreign than any stranger, more distant than any spatial exteriority, and more widely shared than any social bond (such that, as she emphasizes, in the form of revolts or revolutions it can become the basis for a new social bond).

Dufourmantelle often relies upon this sense of the word *intime*. Her chapter on envisaging night, for example, begins: "The night is our secret amplitude. The space of our mute, intimate madness." But her reflections also push the boundaries of this sense to make the word designate the recesses of both space and time. Intimate time is actually a form of untimeliness, the urgency of a past beyond the set of conscious (and perhaps

even unconscious) memories that remind us who we are, the swarming background of virtual experiences (combat without adversary, love without fact, unconscious desire) that lend memories their clarity and distinctness. Dufourmantelle writes of the way in which the earliest body of the newborn, before it is gathered up and organized around a small number of predetermined zones and the specific objects that pertain to them, survives into adulthood:

> Little by little, the body of the newborn is desensitized. It is wrapped up. Little by little, it closes upon itself. Sensations become concentrated around the mouth and the extremities of the body, around what become the so-called erotogenic zones. The memory of the body is thereby divided, dispersed, and forgotten; the entire vibrant body of the newborn goes away, effaced upon contact with the real; but it also lingers to watch over your dreams, your fears, your nightmares; it is lodged within the scents you love; it is suddenly exacerbated as you brush against a passerby; it is volatilized. We spend our lives dismantling this body and trying to recapture it, to rediscover its scent, the miraculous draught of an elixir of lost life. We know intimately that it exists, but no longer dare to believe in it.

Intimacy is commonly understood to characterize a narrow, hushed, insulated, and ultimately maternal sphere of experience, perhaps not devoid of ambivalence. The temporal axis of Dufourmantelle's intimacy, however, reaches further back than the erotogenic body that a mother gives her infant; it confirms what is perhaps the most elementary and indispensable insight of psychoanalysis: that our knowledge spans our entire lives, lived and unlived, remembered and unremembered, personal and impersonal, singular and collective. It was perhaps in the name of this insight that Freud, in his altercation with Jung, refused to allow for a psychoanalysis minus a theory of repression or infantile sexuality. Dufourmantelle, in turn, aligns psychoanalysis with the need for an "intimate rupture," because it (and perhaps it alone) offers hospitality not merely to persons but, more radically, to the whole range of experiences that make up life from the very beginning. "In this sense, yes," she writes, "it is a sort of survival pact."

The most emotionally complex and wrenching moment in James Marsh's documentary about Petit's famous walk, *Man on Wire*, occurs in an interview with Jean-Louis Blondeau, when he describes the experience of watching his childhood friend step out onto the wire that they had just spent a long and exhausting night rigging in secret: "I saw his face changing. He was tense. Then something like relief. From that time, I said,

'That's it. He's secure, it's good.'"[17] After these words, Blondeau smiles nervously and then covers his face as he breaks down in tears. He becomes overwhelmed with emotion at precisely the moment he remembers being certain that Petit was *safe*. This certainty, however, does not come at the end of the exploit when Petit would step *off* the wire and rejoins his accomplices but rather when he ventures *onto* the wire, long before he is officially out of danger. And Blondeau's tears bear witness to a traumatic encounter with a horizon of risk that only opens when Petit's fearlessness, together with his joy, have effectively set aside the possibility of falling.[18]

Risk is beautiful. —PLATO

The instant of decision is madness. —SØREN KIERKEGAARD

To Risk One's Life

Life is a heedless risk taken by us, the living.

Our days take place under the sign of risk: the calculation of probabilities, surveys, the gaming of potential stock market crashes, the psychological evaluation of individuals, natural disaster preparedness, crisis units, cameras. No dimension of ethical and political discourse escapes from it any longer. Today, the principle of precaution has become the norm. In terms of human lives, accidents, terrorism, or social protest, risk is a cursor that moves according to collective mobilization and economic investment; and for precisely this reason it remains an unquestioned value.

"To risk one's life" is among the most beautiful expressions in our language. Does it necessarily mean to confront death—and to survive? Or rather, is there, in life itself, a secret mechanism, a music that is uniquely capable of displacing existence onto the front line we call desire? For risk—its object still indeterminate for now—opens an unknown space. How is it possible, as a living being, to think risk in terms of life rather than death? At the instant of decision, risk calls into question our intimate relationship with time. It is a combat with an adversary whom we never

identify, a desire that we would never know, a love whose face we would never see, a pure event.

How not to question what is to become of a culture that can no longer think about risk except as a heroic act, pure madness, deviant conduct? What if risk traced a territory even before it even accomplished an act? What if it supposed a certain manner of being in the world, constructed a horizon line?

To risk one's life is first, perhaps, not dying. Dying in the midst of our lives, in every form of renunciation, the blankness of depression, sacrifice. To risk one's life at decisive moments of our existence is an act that pushes ahead of us on the basis of a still unknown knowledge, like an intimate prophecy; it is a moment of conversion. Is it this gesture of the prisoner in Plato's myth of the Cave, his turning toward the true light? Or is it, in Kant's discussion of the moral law, this index within us, of universality, which we might take as a basis to think and be free?

As an act, risk lets chance take hold. We would wish it to be voluntary but it originates in obscurity, the unverifiable, the uncertain. I interrogate risk in a manner that does not permit its evaluation or its elimination, within the horizon of: not dying. How are we supposed to imagine that the certainty of our end might not, retroactively, have any effect on our existence? From the furthest edge of this certainty, we know that one day everything we loved, hoped for, and accomplished, will be effaced. And what if not dying in the midst of our lives was the foremost risk of all, refracted in the human proximity of birth and death?

Risk is a *kairos*, in the Greek sense, a decisive instant. And what it determines is not only the future but also the past, a past behind our horizon of expectation, where it reveals an unsuspected reserve of freedom. How should we name that which, in deciding the future, thereby reanimates the past, prevents it from becoming set in stone? Risk is akin to an acoustic phenomenon, the sort of feedback (or Larsen) effect that causes sound to return to its source. When a sound *loops back*, it provokes a kind of secret intelligence that alone, perhaps, is liable to disarm repetition. Far from being a pure "onward" bent on the future, risk subjects time and memory to an inversion of priorities through a sort of revolt, a very gentle and continual rupture. The instant of decision, the one in which a risk is taken, inaugurates an *other* time, much as trauma does. But a positive trauma. Miraculously, it would be the opposite of neurosis whose trademark move is to capture the future in such a way that our present becomes modeled on past experiences, leaving no room for the effraction of the new, for the

displacement, albeit minimal, that opens a horizon line. Indeed, the feedback effect of risk would be the exact opposite. It would be a *rewind* from the future, dismantling the reserve of fatality included in any past, opening a possibility of being in the present—in other words, a line of risk.

Eurydice Saved

Eurydice, a timeless and ultracontemporary figure, is she who for love was sought all the way to death. Taking the risk of *not dying* raises the question of what makes us living beings, but more important, beings like Eurydice with the capacity to call. The myth[1] does not speak of Eurydice's call; and yet this call, and Orpheus's fatal turn back in response to it, is the essence, I believe, of the human bond. Invocation founds our primal bond to the other from our fetal origins unto our end, which traverses and makes us something other than mere intelligent bodies—that is, beings capable of a devastating event: love.

She believed that she would die at thirty. She had always thought so. It would be an appointment no more important than the dentist, an oil change, buying a pack of cigarettes. That morning, she knew, would be just a little more definitive than other mornings. And it wouldn't come from her. Certainly not! She was a stranger to any thought of killing herself, or even praying that chance would do it for her. She simply observed that she had a slight advantage over other people: knowing when the grim reaper would come to collect her. A clairvoyant made an attempt to intercede, saying that it would be no more than a symbolic death, you know, a big emotional shock. Oh really? she smiled, and afterward real life

begins, is that it? She always felt a maternal protectiveness toward clairvoyants, as if visiting them only ever confirmed what she alone knew. What she hadn't foreseen, at all, was fear. A tiny little fear that just arose one rainy afternoon, the way one picks up a lost dog wandering in the street, or a cold. She had caught—or adopted?—a fear. A fear of dying. That was several weeks earlier . . . Then she had come to find him. A shrink, chosen almost at random, because of his voice heard on the radio late one night. She had always gone to sleep listening to the radio; it was her special way of not having had a childhood. Which embarrassed her a little in going to see this gentleman. He would certainly ask her to speak of it, her childhood; but there was nothing that she believed she could remember. But this fear bothered her and, in any event, it wouldn't do to die with such fear stuck to her like a shadow. She'd prefer, if die she must, to do it with grace and serenity. No matter how little she felt like patching together her memories, she would accommodate the man who was willing to listen her. She had very little time left, having started late, but after all it was just a matter of getting someone to help her understand the fear that had suddenly gripped her. Life would be short for her, so what? Having acquired the name of this analyst from the radio station, therefore, she went to her appointment like it was an illicit rendezvous.

The psychoanalyst was late but ultimately the wait allowed her to tame the discomfort of what she had to say to him.

He listened. So far so good, all the same she was expecting that somewhat.

And then he said: "Perhaps you want to live, a little bit more?"

She almost laughed—at the simplicity of the remark, perhaps even its stupidity, its gentleness also.

"Yes, the thought had occurred to me, you know . . ."

"Ah!"

"When you're afraid, isn't it because something you care about is threatened?"

Now it was her asking him questions.

"Yes, no doubt," he added simply.

Then a rather reassuring silence settled in, like a tranquil little breeze in their sails, a navigation to windward. At the end of the session, he accompanied her to the door, supposing that she would return? The following week? At the same time? He didn't specify. He had a sort of contagious goodness, the type that quietly envelops you and leaves you not knowing how to extricate yourself. Clingy, no, courteous, yes, but still with a hint of indifference. It seemed to her that he hadn't taken note of the fast approaching date of her death. They would only have three or four meetings. Well, she trusted in him, she would reflect on the things he had said to her. In truth, she had never thought about the thing like this, since death forbade desire for anything after a certain date. And since she kept death in her sights for thirty years, her life came to resemble the yellowed photographs that one

looks at like a document from another age; it had always been thought in the past tense, starting from that moment of annulment that should be her death.

He hadn't sought to dissuade her about the fatality of this rendezvous—because it was a certainty—as everyone else had tried to do: but Eurydice, look here, you know perfectly well how silly this is, we will raise a glass on your thirtieth birthday and then the day after . . . She didn't object, smiling inside, right, right. . . . The truth is a point of resistance in the real of unequaled force. An experience that functions as a test. It makes the real disgorge itself. And the subject who receives it knows. Eurydice also knew; and she didn't ask anyone to protect her from it.

The following week, he hadn't responded to the intercom. She had rung again and again until the concierge was moved to answer: you're looking for Mr. X?

"Yes, we had an appointment." Then she added, "I believe . . ."

"Ah, I see. So you're not aware . . . Someone should send a notice, they couldn't let everyone know, I understand, but still, it shouldn't be my place to do it!" She had seemed vexed. "He died three days ago now."

Eurydice froze. It was like at eight years old when she witnessed the Aurora Borealis in Canada and had believed, standing before this great green curtain that rattled the entire sky, that it was simply the end of the world.

"Dead?"

"Yes, it was printed in the paper, the burial is tomorrow afternoon. You can call his sister, I think she's the one who responds to his . . . patients," risked the woman after another glance at her.

"Thank you," she said, "but there's no need. You are very kind."

And she exited the building, turning her back on the mute intercom.

In the street, she knew that death had come to pass, that it took someone else. In her place? No, not even. It was just that she would no longer be there at the appointed time. Nonetheless, her fear remained, like a small animal, a kitten left in her care. Now she had to do something with it to help her gain a taste for life. To understand what it was to be alive. An unimaginable event a few moments earlier. It made her think of an accident, a car wreck from which she was miraculously spared. She should pay attention to this life not so much given back but abruptly given to her. This life along with this fear, with his words, and his death.

It sometimes happens that the risk of not dying goes unnoticed, or almost . . . It is not offered as a last resort (to live—still), but rather in what turns out to be a renunciation, in those instants when not believing in anything anymore is all you are capable of. The question, then, is how to change scale? Whether an architect's scale or that of Jacob's ladder, it will be a matter of losing measure, opening a wide angle [*le grand angle*]. Doing an about-face and confronting the past in a radically new manner. Light, one perceives, often comes from behind, from the spot that is called

blind [*dans cet angle que l'on dit mort*]. Or else from a voice that whispers, "Turn around!" The voice of this turn, of revolt, is what pushes you out of the cave, the drugged sleep of depression, any sort of betrayal, or deceptive opinions, in order to go toward what seems only a dream, since you always believed, indeed, you would swear, that the image projected there, on the wall, is the real. Turning around is a true risk. What seems to be renunciation, backpedaling, the obstinacy of one against all, is actually philosophical anamnesis, a certain path of psychoanalysis; it is the madness of believing against all dogma that "back there" is an unequalled reserve of freedom. Back there, Eurydice is the one who whispers: down this path you will confront death, nothing less. If we construct microphilosophies, little fragments of thought around Eurydice, will it help to understand how to climb from death toward life?

Death, we know, is what is risked in us. Holding it imaginarily in our sights is no guarantee that we'll be more living or more loving. If risk is the event of "not dying," it is beyond choice, a physical engagement at close quarters with the unknown, night, nonknowledge, a wager in the face of what, precisely, remains undecidable. It thus opens the possibility that something unhoped for will happen.

Would it not suffice less dramatically to think, with Spinoza, what makes us persevere in being? To think patience instead, this measure of time that, in the face of urgency, cauterizes wounds . . . The patience of being—a subtle, forgotten, uncolonized art of the self, in which emotion is entangled with thought, the cuisine of all creation. But it would have to be a patience neither in the service of waiting, nor especially in that of depression, compromise, or fatal renunciation. This risk—the risk of being—cannot be envisaged or evaluated. The grand machinery of the economy is what promotes the evaluation of risks.

Sometimes, we have mere moments left before it's time. And in the intensity of what's lived in those moments is an infinite surplus of time. A grace, *a Mercy*.[2]

Minuscule Magical Dependencies

"Addiction" is a fashionable word; the Anglicism lends it an aura that the word "dependency" [*dependence*] has lost. Indeed, "dependency" has received very bad press. One grants it a degree of danger in proportion to its level of attraction. Toxic in more than one sense, it arises in the form of any number of more or less powerful substances commonly designated as drugs (which might include the present-day pharmacopoeia of anxiolytic medications) but also the various fruits of biotechnological research, an endless source of fascination. Dependency—we all cozy up to it in secret and demonize it in public.

To be dependent is to be ill, necessarily, because that's what you're told . . . To be dependent on a body, a liquid, an object that becomes fetishized, a ritual, a game, a screen—it's all suspect. And yet, this is where we all start life, in the most naked dependency. Violent, in fact. And our anxieties or our fears sometimes restore us to this newborn's body at the mercy of hunger, thirst, cold, waiting, pain, and the unknown. The sensations that we experience during the first weeks of life are still there, intact, and a particularly strong wave of melancholy is enough to conjure up this body and bend our adult body back toward it. The newborn is handed over to the

other, not only to the good will of her caresses, to care lavished with more or less attention (I avoid the word "love" by design), but also to the moods of her parents, her eventual siblings, and her nannies, no less than to what traverses her from inside, since, just after birth, most likely she remains less detached from the mother and the uterine world than her body is. And when she looks at us with this gaze that, we are told, doesn't yet "see" us, what does she actually perceive? When an adult in an abusive relationship lets herself be treated like garbage, the body of the very little child is what speaks in her and thereby reclaims the attention that no adult is able, or was able, to lavish upon it.

This state of primal dependency, we constantly seek it out and flee from it with the same energy. We play hide-and-seek as grown-ups, having forgotten our childhood somewhere along the line, with the pillow fights, the secrets, the narrow escapes; but who knows what we are looking for, there, among the faces and the nudity of bodies in the openwork weave of landscapes.

To take the risk of dependency is a sign of friendship for this body from just after birth. But this is not all. It is also to think, much like a vaccine that cures a body of a virus by inoculating it with a small dose of the same virus, letting it declare and construct its own defenses, that it's better—even enjoyable—to let our dependencies grow, as in an English garden that keeps wild grasses mixed in with the thyme and dahlias. Not to flee but rather to apprehend them, to lend them our intelligence. Love—now I risk the word, a bit apprehensively to be sure—is an art of dependency. It supposes that one puts oneself at risk. Admitting defeat, senseless expectation, the despair of brusque rejection from the other, letting oneself be devastated by a pain that, it seems at the time, will never end. This acquiescence to dependency is something other than resignation, which suffuses the soul with a fatal venom that sets up any subsequent depression, as when a river dammed up for too long dumps into a swamp. Love is the event that makes us capable of transport into the other, of the act of desertion whereby we choose the adversary over ourselves. Love happens in spite of violence, stupidity, style, envy, and our dreams; it is also constantly ill-timed. In ravishment and disgust, it is a self-dispossession, a disavowal. We have no idea what chimeras are imprinted within us from the first hours of life and that will remerge later, for instance, in the attachment to a certain color of skin, to a certain odor, to this person's gesture, that person's poise, this accent, this slight movement of the hips, this spacing between words.

If dependency is temptation, then we have it to thank for bringing back the figure of the devil. The tempter who engulfed Job in trials speaks the

human condition. Provocation is that to which we might succumb. I mean that even if we resist temptation, if we keep our sights on the tempter as the very special enemy to whom "no" will always be the answer, this refusal is still a form of dependency because he, too, thereby holds us in regard, obliging us to think about him a little every day, if not at every instant. Each of us, in our own manner, deals with the devil. Each has an ongoing conversation with him that she tries to keep totally secret.

In addition, we are not aware of our own dependencies . . . You can know yourself dependent, more or less remorsefully, on condensed milk, on the swallows' cry above the Roman rooftops in springtime, on the adrenaline rush of climbing a rock face with ropes in the midst of a summer sky at three o'clock in the morning, on high heels that carry the ankles like a light handle, on a certain perfume, on porn videos, on lavender honey, on the color red, on bad wine, on staying up all night, on knowing how someone's skin feels before touching it, on B-movies, on fly fishing, on dreaming. But this is only a sketch of the familiar landscape of our addictions. The rest is immersed in night. The night of our humanity. A night that no analysis can penetrate but only skim and perhaps learn to name as one learns words in a foreign language. Because this night is given birth within the uterine body that we no longer remember at all but that still constitutes and carries us.

It is dangerous to underestimate the devil; it is vain to believe that the sheer force of will is enough to ward off temptation—we know this much. It is naïve to imagine that one can be rid of temptation by giving in to it. The hold temptation has over us is strengthened no less by refusal than by the act of yielding to it. Bulimics know this perfectly well, no less than their anorexic kindred: the temptation to reach the limit of the hunger that overwhelms them at every instant ultimately leaves them drained and disgusted with themselves, a state from which they will never be delivered by a pact with hunger, in whatever form it takes. But perhaps it is simply not a matter of wanting to be delivered . . .

To depend on another is not necessarily to surrender body and soul. There is perhaps in this vicinity a "weak" ethics to be found, a minimalist thinking that would attach to the details, the conjunctures, and the minuscule signs of acquiescence of which we are capable in our conversation with the real, and at that moment we can invent eras of microdependency, very tiny landscapes of very violent attachments, with a few bubbles up in the air, as light as dragonfly wings.

Voluntary Servitude and Disobedience

Never will servitude have been so voluntary. How did we get here? To will our servility with all our might, to cherish our bonds, indulgently to regard hierarchies, obedience, and diktats knotted for our own good around our lives like pretty colored ribbons destined to make us forget the iron padlock that fastens them.

Of course this servitude borrows other carefully chosen names. Just as we no longer say "maid" or even "cleaning woman" but rather "household assistant," so we speak of security standards, of public surveillance for a more tranquil life, which everyone hopes for, of increased juridical protection, of elementary safety precautions. It is a question of living better, ergonomics, noncontamination—in brief, maximum security. Oh yes! We are free, of course . . . Free, first of all, not to subscribe to any of it. It is like a damage waiver,[1] the never-ending and migraine-inducing calculation of probabilities, which you countersign, heeding the little voice that urges you to do it. Taste dictates that one extol the principle of disobedience but act like a well-behaved, patient citizen, complacent but not ungrateful to a democracy that does the best it can. "A century ahead of time," writes Annie Le Brun, "Alfred Jarry identified the things that our world seeks to liquidate: my

singularity, love, and recklessness. However, he also foresaw the monstrous way in which this liquidation would occur, *with the manufacture of soul.*"[2]

Taking the risk of disobeying supposes the capacity to obey—an other obedience, if you will—at the behest of something other than the conscious ego. Otherwise, disobedience becomes mere caprice, nothing more than bravado or unpremeditated acts under the sway of drives that are more or less justified after the fact. To obey is first to be able to speak. To have entered the grammar of a language, to have espoused its codes the better to subvert them, to retread the path that goes from Joyce back to Bescherelle. Language is the first place of our obedience; it is the nonciphered arithmetic of a memory, a civilization, a transmission—the first condition of our possibility for disobedience. Like any true ethics, language opens many passageways, but, above all, a certain relation of otherness to oneself. Understanding that obeying is reflexive, the English say *self-obedience*, coining a term that we lack in French. Self-obedience would be to respect the fact that we are not entirely subjective, that the ego is only a part of ourselves, albeit the part that governs us and founds our identity. But certain experiences do not demand the consent of a subject; they simply "happen" and happen to us, that's all, and we happen to be at this specific place for just a moment, just for an event of this world. To be obedient "to oneself" is to recognize the existence of an inalienable place that the subjective does not entirely contain. In the Middle Ages, the "heart of hearts" [*for intérieur*] perhaps designated, albeit with manifestly spiritual overtones, this "other" space inside of oneself that, even under torture, cannot be surrendered—by which I mean that, even in confessing, a person does not have the power to offer up to her tormentor this impregnable and universal place of her freedom.

Would disobedience merely be second obedience, in the Kierkegaardian sense, far from the blind loyalties that urge us to renunciation and compromise? Perhaps one should begin there . . . to act upon this self-obedience that makes it possible to say no. We are human because we are beings of language and promise, but we are also in large part immersed in the immanent experience of the world. Disobedience is the traversal of mirages, a manner of lightheartedly breaking bonds, because one has agreed to lose everything, including life. Yes, there is a gentleness of insolence that is stronger than any tyranny, but it is also the breeziness of humor. In the face of the ineluctable, wit abides. Another response is possible; one can step aside, no matter where one happens to be. To disobey is among the greatest risks because the cataclysm that it triggers is incommensurate with what it opposes. There where resignation is demanded, it remains possible, not to settle, or to argue, but simply to "prefer not to."

In Suspense

> Desire is knowledge deferred, but made visible in the impatience of the suspense in which it is held.
>
> —MICHEL FOUCAULT, *Lectures on the Will to Know*

To be in suspense is to hold your breath. And to look with as much attention as possible at what is simply there, at what offers itself to you in the presence of things.

The ordeal is in this balance conquered above the void: at every moment, it could be lost. The high-wire artist risks falling, most of all when he holds still, when he attempts to stay in place, almost without moving a muscle. He must restrain the very momentum that gives him stability. As a high-wire artist, he prefers to attempt this miracle of suspense out on the wire. It might be said that he is waiting—but something else is happening. Suspension is not the arrested time that comes *before* something else happens; it is the event itself—the passage into the intimate time where, in reality, the decision has already been made but no one knows it yet.

Taking the risk of being in suspense is rather acrobatic, therefore. We admire the force and suppleness of the trapeze artists who open their arms into the void, and their particular way of attempting the leap. Brief glimpses of takeoff. When it comes to philosophy, the expected qualities are the same . . . except that there are neither platforms, nor trapezes, nor people to catch you; you proceed blindly with a certain idea of truth to delimit the arena.

Suspending judgment, from ancient Greece to Descartes, is the moment of crisis, the place of the *epoché*. Of philosophizing itself. It is to be suspended upon a conceptual swing without ever really touching ground, and to choose *not to* . . . Not to judge, not to decide, not to act. Not yet, not right now. To remain as long as possible in this untenable posture that internally commands you to remain at the disposal of . . . And not to trust any prefabricated or predigested concept. To remain as far as possible from thinking calcified into postures, responses, and certainties, but still to think.

Suspense is a negation of action that would be action itself, as Far Eastern civilizations have perfectly described. To suspend is not to wait, to delay out of fear or indecision. It does not imply an eventual passage to the act; it can also erase itself, dissolve into its own withdrawal. It is already the event itself in its effective "nonaction."

Cameras produce suspense in the form of still images. Their function: the pause.

What risk do we take when we suspend a decision—a marriage, a dirty trick, a craving for sweets, a decision to die? Do we wager that something else will intervene, that an inner determination, a sort of slow upheaval will carry our being away down an imperious path? The die is cast and we wish to be relieved of fate, joyous (more or less) marionettes in a world of dupes. Suspense causes us to doubt our very identity, Descartes tells us in *Meditations*. Doubt is the acolyte of suspense—its gravedigger, its messenger. The subject of doubt claims the right not to believe what she sees, to examine the very thing that she doubts, to encircle the enemy's territory. Does suspending the faculty of judgment offer the same refuge or is it merely an unconscious maneuver to delay the inevitable? If doubt is the actualization of thinking itself and not only a triage station for sorting what stays or goes, what must be thought or not, then we should apprehend a mode of being in suspense that is lighter, more metaphysical, and more overwhelming than any belief.

This, we might recall, is a function of what Kant calls the aesthetic Idea: through it, imagination does violence to understanding by forcing it to "think more," even though this surplus of thinking can never be grasped in an adequate concept (cf. *Critique of Judgment*, §49). If the aesthetic idea manifest in a sensible form remains unreachable, it is because there is no way to make it correspond to any determined content of consciousness. Is the aesthetic idea, mobilizing a supposedly deceptive emotion, a suspension of the true? Is this risk, solely represented in an embodied Idea, enough to awaken a different relation to what commonly we call the real?

In our latitudes, the imaginary generally calls up an age-old mistrust. It is reduced to a subaltern function, a cheap escape for weary minds. We take flight, so we say, into an imaginary world. In Pascal's most beautiful pages on distraction, once again he presents the faculty of imagination in the guise of escape from self, flight beyond the world, and the mirages of attachment. Yet this "suspense" of the imaginary gives rise to creation as creativity and not simply—as too often thought—as the capacity to produce illusion, chimera, and disavowal. In our relation to imagination and the possibility of suspending judgment, the will is what finds itself thwarted from acting and must undergo, with the wire walker's step that I evoked a moment ago, its own essential passivity.

It is dangerous to undermine the belief that the subject might regain her "self" and construct herself through an immediate decision. This belief forms the armature of our myths, the very root of the political. But it is mere fiction that the subject will find herself in action, a greater fiction than anything else. But it is attractive. We have such a strong desire to recognize ourselves in our acts, our judgments, our assertions. Whereas, in fact, metaphors, nebulous images, and uncertainties describe us best. Being in suspense returns us to the penumbra, to a point of relative blindness, and to a certain manner of holding fast to this point. Holding fast, something else appears, another limit, another shore.

When the subject does not succumb to the mirages of intentionality, when she attempts to disengage from her acts, from her projections, from her movements of identification, she ends up, in a certain sense, disgorging subjectivity itself. A sort of universality is experienced at this threshold. The wire walker's step, suspended so close to the void, is perhaps not so much that of the person walking but rather of a whole body become balance. The suspension of judgment is difficult and highly artificial; it is an exhausting exercise, because what the subject risks encountering is something heterogeneous to its nature. Something that cannot be absorbed into her identity, arriving from the unfamiliar, untamed borderlands of the real. This is what horrifies the ordinary neurotic, whose principal impulse is, at any price, to make the unknown known again. Philosophy, by essence the first space for questioning, is an art of suspense.

"Tell me what I should do. I just don't know anymore. I don't understand anything anymore. I obsess. I haven't been able to sleep. What should I do? Give me an answer . . ."

The silence of the analyst opens a suspense. It is not a nonresponse or a nonreception; it is an engagement with the nonresolution of an act, an invitation to take

further risks, to hold unbearable contradictions within oneself and bring them alive.

"You do not answer . . . then why do I even speak to you? Why do I come here each week to hurl myself against your silence? And yet, if you weren't there, I wouldn't still be standing. I just wish so much that you could point out a somewhat clear path to me, a direction to go in . . ."

To suspend, this is also what the analyst attempts to do. Not to judge but to let resonate in herself the patient's speech, her asphyxiated dreams, her devastated expectations, her renunciations—to listen to the tyranny that lies under the complaint, the onrush of tears beneath the façade of happiness, the terror before the unknown. Again and again. In this suspense for two, the ordinary limits of the ego are skirted into a vaster space where there is no need to decide but only to let happen. To suspend, yes, but together. In a common space, an instant is set aside in which nothing need be decided, nor learned, nor expected, nor (above all) renounced. To let a thread of a truth bare itself, a truth that cannot be demanded. Even less could it become the object of a deal or a debt. A truth evinced that arrives just like a letter arrives, one day. The "in suspense" is contiguous to the space of the love letter, to an inner retreat, necessarily spiritual, whatever these words designate. How to take the risk of protecting this retreat without haste or violence? To linger there where thinking—which is also to say, emotion—moves. Not to destroy anything, to observe, to pacify. To let thinking unfold, extend, and emerge from its errors. Then the world gets lighter.

At the Risk of Passion

Nothing takes care of passion but passion.

—CHARLES FOURIER

Passion is not advisable. And yet, everyone keeps watch for it; everyone secretly wants to catch this mortal illness. Ruin of the family, destruction of a slow burning and true love life, little factory of amorous mirages, toxic source of attachment, illusory imprint, machinery of a desire that wishes to be eternal but always turns out to be ephemeral and essentially narcissistic, throughout history passion has been accused of every ill and awaited in secret by all.

And yet, passion is a risk we all take because our will is so paralyzed when the conjugated effects of the flesh and the heart overwhelm our affects without possible escape. At a minimum, it arises and launches us into the strange ballet of misrecognition: tell me who I am and I will love you . . . this truth that one expects from the other is a weapon that can easily be turned against us.

But how can passion be a risk if it proves inevitable? It is a one-sided wager that commits you to chance, luck, or any other face of the unpredictable. This wager convokes you, in return, to exist within it—by which I mean that it takes hold of you, it is a state of being, a precipitate of time and the act in which you are wholly gathered, with unparalleled intensity.

This intensity is the brute name of passion. One can refuse it, close the chapter of the book that Alice cracked open, not run after any white rabbits, and return to everyday life. Nothing is easier. Show over. But once swept into the movement whereby everything lived takes on a different quality, there is no going back to the language you used before; no word retains the same flavor, the same sense; you no longer have the same body, the same hunger.

Passion is the very substance of risk. It is the remainder of a passivity within us that flares up with the least abrasion, with the possible inversion of night into light, of ice into torrent, or of silence into a cry; it is our capacity to imagine, to be astonished, to be disappointed, impressed, or undone by something inside us that compels us to love this skin, this gaze, this accent, every detail of this being astir right in front of us, a brief apparition of naked life.

Etymologically speaking, passion comes from *passio*, the action of undergoing, the fact that to experience passivity at the cardinal point of our being is also to accept being left in the unknown, losing your points of reference and sometimes your very identity. One can choose a path but not tell the wind where to blow. You attempt to master your heart or at least the acts that issue from it. Believing it possible is enough most of the time.

Elie During says it remarkably well: "If love has never been what makes 'one' of two beings, but rather, on the contrary, disjoins them from one another and each from himself, then its condition is the impossible self-coincidence in which desire is conjugated with death."[1] Everything is a matter of consent, or of refusal. This is our responsibility, to say yes or no. And how do you love and never forget that you have loved—in spite of the betrayals, wrongs, denials, nobility, generosity, and yes, even in pain? To hold fast. The pure enchantment of this light . . . like joy, you can either delve into it or not let yourself be affected. Passion is not possession. It is espousing a movement that dispossesses and reveals you at the same time. Against the common wisdom, there is a terrible truth in passion. *A sharp edge.*[2] It is accepting the inadequacy, the discrepancy, the inequality that inhabits any fusion and is delivered from it; but it is a birth for one who really gives in to it.

To abandon yourself—who among us is capable of this? I mean truly abandon yourself, for once in your life, unreservedly. Abandon yourself supposes an other to whom you abandon yourself, an other who does not demand as much, who is also afraid, and who protects herself. To abandon yourself is to confront abandonment, the fear lurking deep within us that never lets us out of its sight. Illusion—but of what? Of promises of

forever, of fidelity? Yes. Of peaceful life, of forgetting, of violence against the family? Yes. Passion is torturous. It makes waiting an infernal ordeal. Delay lends itself to a thousand imaginings. Any breach of trust becomes a potential terror in which betrayal already looms. What passion gives us to live comes only at such a price: exorbitant.

Passion brings us back to the ancient opposition between nature and culture, to the primitiveness that Kierkegaard describes, to an unclaimed terror without language, and to savagery, as if murder and passion were always bound up with one another. And what if, on the contrary, passion was liberating, if it *broke us free*?[3] What if, inversely, passion elevated us—in the sense of a paradoxical education of the soul—and was extremely troubling? What if it convoked us to refinement, to the lovable, to the instant, to the wisdom of the body, to be grateful for what is given rather than what is owed? What if its value resided in intensity rather than in anxiety, in penumbra rather than in daylight? The most painful thing about passion is that it drives us to betray our promises, our attachments, and our moral principles, or to hurt those we love. This is why we often prefer to renounce passion, to turn away from it.

She could not stop speaking and sobbing. Her words got lost in her tears and came out scrambled, or blurred, giving the impression of an incredible mishmash. A cloying and sugary stew. She lay on the couch and spoke almost without taking a single breath, spoke of him without stopping, of missing him to death, suddenly interrupting herself sometimes for a second to say, straining back toward the analyst, up on one elbow, "There is no way you can understand, this is all pointless," and then she curled up again, the dark stain of her body on the worn velvet, her voice distraught. She spoke of the man who left her for reasons that she found absurd, and yet she said he would never come back; the very ridiculousness of this reason made getting back together impossible; everything was ruined, permanently. Nothing other was imaginable anymore. In this breakup, she became a pure reverberation of the pain of lack. The sessions went on like this until, one day, the psychoanalyst noticed a particularly beautiful pigeon at her window. He became absorbed in contemplation of the bird while the patient unfurled her suffering, the impossible suture of a devastated love. As a result, he missed the last few words. After which, she fell silent. This abrupt silence was upsetting. He very quickly sought to reconstruct what had just been said, but to no avail. He returned to the pigeon, which had flown off. And she wasn't crying. She said nothing.

Petrified, he no longer even dared to look at her. The silence was supernatural. But what did she say, finally, to put an end to this blizzard of words against the background of a war that had been lost?

So he remained silent as well.

Six minutes went by and each minute seemed three times as long. The bird didn't return; but the analyst kept watching for it, as if the bird's reappearance could bring back the memory of words lost to an attention that was not only floating but above all distracted by an animal with a fine white border that had the privilege of flying off over the rooftops.

"He didn't love me anymore, I think."

Her voice was no longer the same. As if she had climbed out of an immense sadness, dragging with her a fund of empty sobs, she was clear, articulate, and precise.

"I was crying over a phantom, a love that no longer existed. It was killing me. I had even filled my pockets with rocks in order to drown myself. Look, I kept one."

From her pocket she took a medium-sized stone, of a slightly irregular shape, light gray and white like those found in Bretagne.

"I have a lot just like this one, oh sure! They wouldn't have been enough—but with the cold and the dark, who knows? To whom would I have given all this love, can you tell me?"

The silenced analyst hardly dares to breathe; he has trouble believing what he is hearing; he doesn't recognize anything, as if it's from a forbidden radio frequency, with unknown acoustic signals. This woman, his patient for nine years, he no longer knew who she was . . . All of a sudden, everything was effaced—her history, her tears, the mad and devouring passion that left no room for her life. He only said to himself that the bird would never return, nor would she; that he understood nothing, heard nothing; that something unprecedented happened in the lapse of time—a few minutes, seconds?—when he got lost in contemplation of the bird; that speech can sometimes return all at once and along with it freedom.

Each of us hopes for passion; each hopes for it and runs from it, always keeping our guard up in the face of this imaginary enemy who makes us abdicate everything in favor of a violent servitude. Inextinguishable. Hours spent waiting, crying, falling to pieces. There is a sort of astonishment from which one never recovers. A quality of presence that Virginia Woolf, in *To the Lighthouse*, transcribed almost blindly, a light dusting of vacuity, things superimposed on one another, on the horizon, gossamer layers of insomnia, skin against skin, forgetting, dreams, memory, highly saturated life.

We want intensity without risk. Which is impossible. Intensity is the leap into the void, the unknown part of ourselves that has yet to be written and yet awaits us, some precise thing. Passion is a disposition born within us since childhood that can be enlarged or diminished—but totally altered, never. Like Kierkegaard's knight of faith, it demands passage to the infinite, a hyperbole. The path is not defined, nor the how, nor the conventions, nor the reason that might show the way. Love harbors such risks. And yet it remains plagued by so many repetitions . . . For, afterward, so soon after the initial vertigo, fear takes over, and then it's just the same old patterns that don't take long to register the defeat of feeling. What then? Must we not believe in renunciations, alibis, oaths, mirages, and yet love? Knowing that desire is what wants, everything falls into place around it, more or less secretly. And desire is attached to the body—but a body outside the body, which is the soul as well, impossible to gather in a word, in a vision, or in an act. No pact can determine its limits or duration, except for sex that does not exhaust itself in *jouissance* or in repetition. Who would wish for such deliverance?

But there is another passion, or at least an event that goes by the name of Passion, that of Christ. The passion of incarnation, of a god made man. Does this Passion simply designate martyrdom, the tormented body of he who let himself be condemned and betrayed by a friend? Or does this word designate another event that gestures, amidst humility and betrayal, toward another possibility of the most sacred, that evokes acquiescence to an absolute elsewhere? Whether we are believers or not, this Passion belongs to our memory, to our relation to the world and language. Every passion, in this sense, pays tribute to this other, Christic scene, which offers us the possibility of turning savagery into grace.

Leaving the Family

The bourgeois family, thanks to the combined efforts of the Napoleonic Code and Hegelian philosophy, has received the justification of an ethics grounded in economy and the assurance of its perpetuation. From the simple social contract that ensures the cohesion of the species and the name, to the transmission of a heritage and culture, from one war to the next, the family saw itself increasingly freighted with an ideal whereby what one persists in calling "love" is measured in terms of specific facts and weighty responsibilities. Since then, times have changed it seems. As family bonds loosen, however, haven't we seen the ideal become more firmly fixed? And a certain idea of love perpetually brought back within the familial fold? Starting a family, indeed, remains the supreme commitment. We prostrate ourselves on the altar of an immobile eternity in which Prince Charming embraces Snow White under a leaden sky while the weeping dwarves promise they will have many children. We applaud. Entertainment magazines such as *Gala* and *VSD* have replaced the Brothers Grimm but nothing, or almost nothing, has changed. We say goodbye to love or to children but not the family; we confine ourselves to narrow circles of artists or doctors and with studied behaviors, we produce eternal

adolescents, little clones seriously committed to replicating their elders, all the same.

To leave one's family, origin, city of birth, the déjà vu and the assurance of seamless familiarity—what singular life does not come at such a price? Being unfaithful—psychically, genealogically—to what has not been handed down with love but ordered, psychologically, genealogically, under threat of destitution. The initiatory ordeal of a second birth is always, and more than ever, necessary. We must depart, extract ourselves from our codes, our allegiances, our heritage. Any work comes at such a price. And any love, I believe. Depression is the flipside of departure. It is not being able to disentangle oneself, to dispossess oneself, or to disburden oneself in time, to ditch everything in order to risk one's life.

To leave the family is also to mourn an originary place to which one belongs by right or even in fact, a place that would hold the key to our intimate belonging, to our ability to be recognized. This standard measure whereby—alas—everything else is evaluated will never restore what has been lost (a childhood, a first love)—that is, the burden of a debt that is incommensurable with all else. Nothing could ever erase this expectation; the verdict will always be adverse; Kafka will always be sent to his room, far from Felice.

Leaving the family behind opens toward the risk of love. Toward a certain coldness of heart. For love is no downy nest, nor is it a tangled web of hatred and envy in which we seek to curl up over and over again. No, love is often frigid. It arises with the irreparable, wounds, remorse, jealousy and forgiveness, expectation, and solitude—everything contrary to what goes by the name of love also comes with actual love. This freedom gained at the price of blood relations can also help us to love our family members, but from an *other* place, not more detached, but free of the debt that commands obedience and compels acquiescence to all violence. The risk of leaving the family is an unrealized elegy to the fugue, to distance, to evasion. To that in us that is capable of being disoriented.

Why is the family so often a hell, forgiven each time it begins all over again, whose singular imprint or flavor we seek to regain throughout lives? What should be believe? We are fortune tellers, soothsayers; we are afraid of being abandoned so we create refuges the better to destroy them, abandon them, or let them perish. There is no end to leaving the family except by recreating friendship and intelligence with blood relations; it is a movement without remorse, passionate, slightly mad, to find elsewhere what makes of us beings capable of love and joy, liberated from the scenarios of a past outside of memory.

Forgetting, Anamnesis, Deliverance

So we beat on, boats against the current,
borne back ceaselessly into the past.

—F. SCOTT FITZGERALD, *The Great Gatsby*

To remember is to forget. We live in an amnesiac epoch that venerates memory as never before. Digitized, formatted, and extolled, but contracted out for a fee, we want to protect it at all costs, to construct altars to it, and be able to access it at any time. Everything is a pretext to struggle against forgetting: museums, foundations, archives, recordings, posthumous publications; whatever means are used to exhume, to postdate, to rediscover, to date, or to classify, they will become necessary. More than ever before, our civilization seeks to commit to memory—definitively, technologically, and unassailably—its past betrayals and omissions no less than its glory. Any effacement is suspect, likewise any distraction; and the irreversible disappearance of a clue, or even a memory, is graver still. Even in psychoanalysis, the issue has been decided: one never forgets anything. Somewhere in the obscure chamber of memory, it is ordained that everything will remain engraved. It will be returned to you. Keep your hopes up, even forgetting won't last forever. For, such effacement is the mark of a sterile lack, a grave inconsistency. Yes, the possibility of forgetting—yourself or the world—is more and more intolerable to us. It confronts us with our incapacity to learn lessons from history writ large, or even from our small

personal histories . . . as if it permitted the endless repetition of the errors, the failures, and the blindness that presides over crime. It legitimates in some way our guilty amnesia. And the repetition that it authorizes forms a strange litany.

In early childhood, forgetting is acceptable. With lassitude, like an overtaxed mother, we abandon this past since, from these early years, almost nothing remains but scraps of memory that might have been altered, decomposed, and recomposed by design. And this remainder makes a past that suits our needs. Nietzsche writes: "A thing must be burnt in so that it stays in the memory: only something that continues to hurt stays in the memory."[1]

Safekeeping, today, is a matter of urgency. Everything, no matter what, just don't let it get lost, for pity's sake. Come on, still not enough. Not only must we rescue the endangered species on our planet, we are also summoned to fight like a prostrate army against all forgetting. It is necessary to understand . . . Forgetting is an attack on the work of memory—that is, on humanity's duty to itself to remember. Magical fiction. Utopia against disaster. And the living past that this humanity—ours—would like endlessly to archive is a storehouse of testimonies to genocide, to attacks, to unprecedented forms of violence, retrieving from silence the destiny of the sacrificed. The desire for archives is important; it is indeed a duty to remember; but no "archive fever" will relieve us of our responsibility—collectively and singularly—for what happened. The struggle against forgetting has been extended in a troubling way to all forms of safekeeping, perhaps helping us to avoid a different, savage relationship to our past. The cheap, globalized discourse of guilt that surrounds big events, their anniversaries insipidly solemnized in the media, becomes a front for the distraction, in the Pascalian sense, that has taken hold of a civilization haunted by its past but dancing on its dead.

We are, we will be—the accusation is hereby leveled—guilty of nonmemory, of self-possessiveness: by name, by identity, by genealogical traceability, by address, by milieu. Forgetting sows disorder; just imagine, you might almost forget yourself . . . From the viewpoint of social, moral, and personal conscience, forgetting is treated as a sort of suspect free zone, in the image of countries that harbor off-shore investment schemes. Amnesia is tolerated only if judged politically indispensable.

Forgetting slips between our fingers like sand, or smoke; it thwarts closure, certainty. Strangely, it has much in common with ecstasy. Forgetting unsettles everything that sustains the subject—her objects, rituals, certainties, discoveries. It has capricious affinities with death, like the effacement

of traces, of everything that constituted an existence. It gestures toward the groundlessness from which we emerge, reminds us that, four generations from now, at best no more will remain of a single life than an anecdote, a piece of writing, a bad photo, and often nothing at all. Must we acknowledge, then, that erasure is met with erasure? To forget is a verb. A verb as paradoxical as can be, because it just takes from intelligence a share of its past and offers only night in return. To forget opens a space of availability to the unknown, to something whose possibility hasn't been safeguarded but that will still be delivered to us.

He had forgotten his name, his life. His memory was totaled along with his car in an accident that killed the wife whom he loved (so he was told). There were a few photos of her in their apartment, but they evoked nothing for him, except perhaps the admiration he could muster for her unaffected beauty, now shattered. Otherwise, he was unscathed, as people say. He would have preferred to leave behind a chunk of his body or to have a scar on his face, something that would at least attest to the shock that left him without a past, worse than someone born with X for a name. An adopted child can at least dream of his family, or grapple with his disgrace; he can concoct a story, hope that something will happen—be resolved, be revealed. He had nothing but scattered archives, the basis for a bad screenplay. Photos in two more or less unfinished albums made up the collage of a couple's life that he didn't understand in the least: a first marriage, no children, and then this apparently beloved woman who died right next to him, an old-time beauty, a type of very pale blond, her body bent out of shape. None of this managed to elicit any feeling, any emotion, an inkling of recognition . . . He had had a profession, as his papers bore witness: an architect (not so bad) of gardens (bizarre), and recently (according to invoices) he had even specialized in golf course design, which today could not seem more absurd (since he wouldn't even know by which end to grip a club).

He was sent to a "shrink." To ask what . . . ? To bring back emotions that he knew were irrecoverable? To attempt to piece together lost images, patiently, one by one, while going over each clue from his past or to invent himself a new past? To help him connect to something, no matter how slight, that might provide a trace, furrow the violent waters of forgetfulness? He didn't believe it. He went to devise a formula for survival—for now.

"But," I ask him, "from what did you wish to be so brutally delivered?"

He seemed tired. Possibly drank too much, with rosacea and white hair, but otherwise he had a rather handsome Roman appearance. Of Italian origin, judging by his name. But the origin is precisely what escaped him, and especially to feel it as his own.

"Delivered? But from nothing! In any event, I couldn't be now, right? I'll always lose at this game because I have forgotten who I was. I only have scraps of dreams to tell and they make me want to vomit. It was an accident, I mean truly an accident. The other car ran a red light. He was ok, not us. That's how it is. Nothing to blame but chance."

"And now"

"You are asking what I expect from you, right? That you give me back the desire to invent an identity, not just any identity but almost... provided that I feel something."

"If you don't feel anything, then it's not just forgetting. Forgetting manages only memories, not the sensorium, and even less the emotional register. Whence my first question . . . which chance alone cannot answer."

"And so no more than chance can, you can do nothing for me. It would seem that you're a manager of memories, you oversee clearance sales, wholesale and retail."

I smiled.

"You know perfectly well that you will not find an ad hoc identity here, but at most a new manner of gaining access to the elements that compose you, to what keeps you together, what animates you. Burnt skin, grafted skin, continues to be your skin, and remains organically bound to your body, otherwise it would die, rot, and so would you. You need to find a self-graft that takes."

"I could begin with this woman, try to understand who she was, how I loved her, what we did together. She was alive not so long ago."

"Instead, look there where you—you died"

"Is that a hint? Advice? A path to follow?

"It is what I feel."

I thought that feeling was precisely what he was exiled from; that returning to what in him was cut off from all feeling would be impossible; that in this distressing zone where everything was blank, undifferentiated, there would be an imprint, a thought that would tell him not who he used to be but rather who he might perhaps become, like the core of a rope around which the strands are braided. To discover whether a small remnant could be saved, it would no longer suffice to wander around looking in the penumbra; he would have to follow to the trail of crumbs that he had relegated to the hallway, there where he was today, he who wasn't so dead.

What can you, what do you *want* to save from oblivion—that is, what do you want, among everything that has been forgotten, not to find again but to make come back as if by miracle to the surface of the world? To enact this sudden grace that, suddenly, renders present what had been

subtracted, then erased. Along with the impossible return to self whose price only amnesiacs know.

The analysis would last a few years. The memories never came back. But something, out of oblivion, did come. Came back within the very time of what should be called a new life. An other love, an other apartment, different tastes, and a profession that happened almost by chance. Thanks to a passion for scuba diving in which it turned out that he was especially gifted, he became a deep sea diving instructor. There couldn't be a more precise metaphor for what he gave up looking for in himself—the traces, the vestiges, the unexploited, and unfindable resources of what had constituted what is commonly called an identity. What came back was the sensation of having a body. His own—that is, a body that also came from the past, made of images and fears, hesitations, sensitivities, and urges that came from beyond him; and little by little this body took its place within him like a transplanted heart, not entirely foreign and not yet himself. In a sense, forgetting became his friend—a risk run, yes, like a risky hand in poker that you play anyway to see what happens.

Isn't forgetting a reserve of time—of love—afforded for what remains? A civilization that refuses to forget anything condemns us to live as amnesiacs, given that all recording gets exported outside of us, outside of our control, decreeing that it will now be taken care of for us, like so many other things. "But it is necessary to ask," writes Emmanuel Lévinas, "whether the proper meaning of consciousness does not consist in being a vigilance backed against a possibility of sleep."[2] Forgetting, like sleep, is a deliverance, not only an agency of repression, avoidance, and misrecognition. What it delivers is not the same thing as that from which it delivers *us*.

Incurable (In)fidelities

It is the faithless who know love's tragedies.

—OSCAR WILDE, *The Picture of Dorian Gray*

Infidelity is a wound, for each of us, often incurable. Infidelity to whom, to what? The term supposes, implicitly, more primordially than all else, a promised, supposed, or wished for fidelity that forms the horizon of our attachments. But what if being unfaithful was the risk, who knows, of the greatest love?

Juxtaposed instants. A garden, a river—the river. Literature, the river again. Gentle evenings like orgies in which nothing happens. August nights, planets in slow revolution. Slow rock 'n' roll, friendship. But a friendship that would just be love, nothing other. Two little girls in white dresses lying in the too big hammock. Their shining eyes, their lust for life and their insouciance. A ribbon of music unfurling the whole time. The death of a very old and beloved lady, interred with a psalm and the whole memory of generations—in her, with her, carried away. Other mornings, the river yet again, the noise of branches lapping the water in summer. And what if all this happened to disappear? To believe that it will last indefinitely, with slight and loving displacements of things, the planting of linden trees, a basin carried from one house to another, old garden lavender and roses, a sour lemon tart, duck confits and wine to get slightly drunk on evenings when, like lost children, you promise to grow old together and stay in love forever.

I listen. The evocation of that summer sends me back to my own life, to summers long gone, to the laughter of children not yet grown, to the diffuse warmth of August mingled with the torpor of bodies, to interminable siestas, and to boredom as well. The patient continues her evocation and there is a sad quality in her voice that I would like to be able to grasp, protect from a more brutal attack. From a fracture? She tells me that everything happened because a door slammed shut. Just like that, a gust of air through the old house not far from the river. It was on the second floor; she had gone upstairs to close the window. That's where she heard his voice. He was talking to someone, on the telephone, in a voice that she didn't recognize. In spite of herself, she stopped. The walls were very thin so she even heard him whispering. Which is when her heart started to beat violently, like when a child's emotion is so strong she seems about to faint. And yet it was nothing serious, just the tone of this amorous voice that had broken into the old house. His voice was so tender, that was it no doubt, she heard the words that he uttered to another: "I wish you were here, with me." And then the murmur again, which bespoke the desire to make love, at once arousal and gentleness. She entered the room, the conversation had stopped. Interrupted as an effect of her own arrival, of her obvious distress. He had understood right away, had not hid anything, had not defended himself. He had remained silent.

"How do you accommodate such a thing from someone whom you love—another love?" she asks me. "I was the one who loves and who cries. I was the one who waits and who didn't want to interrupt anything, the one who seeks to know and who prefers not to know, who acquiesces and at the same time violently refuses. I understood that he wanted to live a hundred lives, that he sought excitement against boredom, not a boredom from childhood but the boredom of life itself, of being alive in spite of everything. This woman brought her sorrow and her vulnerability, with her lively sensibility and her queenly bearing. I had seen them together and yet I had seen nothing. Life isn't possible for him any other way, I know. He wouldn't want to hurt me, he just wanted it to be possible without inflicting pain . . . And I am devastated."

The session was almost over but I couldn't bring myself to say a word to signal the end, not then, not like that. When I don't know what to say and yet I feel I must offer the rescue of a word, I think of the Greeks, because they had the genius of their language, but also because in this detour and the avowal of my own incapacity to respond to the scandal of this woman's pain there is a link that I am trying to weave; because others have felt and thought the same thing; and there is no such thing as total isolation, even in the absolute solitude of the feeling of betrayal. I told her that the Greeks distinguished two movements within desire: the desire to consent to a choice and desire as desire. But do we know who stops at wanting and who desires? "We are women," writes Euripides. "Sometimes we fall prey to hesitation; sometimes our audacity is unsurpassed . . . Nature wanted someone with absolute disregard for the laws; and this is why woman was born."[1]

She turned back toward me and this "turning back" pleased me. "You understand," she said, "I fought for him to speak to me, not to extort confessions (which confessions?) or to make him talk about her, or for myself, but rather for a precise risk, the risk of the truth of love. I don't care about the possession of bodies, nor vows and the lies that necessarily come with them. And he did speak, a little. The next day I wrote a very short message to this woman and she responded very simply. Just a few words that avowed her own love, with an infinite respect. I would have liked to write to her again . . . But I didn't. Do you understand? I became haunted. I was no longer at the river, I was no longer in the starry night, I had been caught up in this rupture that makes you disgorge such a strange ungraspable pain that no word could then nor can it now, even as I am speaking to you, here, render its madness. Its absurdity, its disorientation, its idiocy. It's a strange shipwreck, but why? Why this sadness, I don't know . . . I wanted to join them, to be with them, and I couldn't. Same as when I was a child, all the time."

I thought that she, too, wanted to experience several lives, like him, or else why would she have sought this man before all others? Is it really believable that life strews our path with beings who are absolute strangers? What we call infidelity is a form of exile outside of oneself. We are castaways, stranded on islands as large as childhood from which we return utterly drained, full of nostalgia and terror. We want to be alone but in the midst of a party, together but also alone in the breadth of life; we want dreams in touch with other bodies, other desires, other lives, but we are afraid and sometimes we die, slowly, suffocated under the weight of loyalties we prefer to know nothing about. And when we discover that the other, the beloved is unfaithful, the world suddenly loses its meaning and its human measure. The very possibility of attachment is withdrawn, and speech along with it, its trustworthiness, its aid. Everything becomes a vector of possible betrayal. But love comes at such a price. Unfaithful we are, all of us will be, sooner or later. Neither skin nor sex impose a limit. Only spirit does, and the ties of the heart. The obsessive presence of an other, suddenly, within us.

"Doesn't infidelity begin with oneself?" I ask her as gently as possible. "Doesn't it begin with our own infinite misrecognition of ourselves, with the lies, the alibis, the pretexts, and the excuses that are born, with language itself as a weapon of desire?"

It is necessary to have loved, and betrayed, and suffered, and despaired of a love, and to have been undone and taken back and saved, in order to envisage, perhaps, that there is only infidelity where love is the greatest, but that, at the same time, love can only be risked at the price of truth—that is, of an impossible promise to belong completely to yourself and to

the other but as far as possible from any possession. We have to respond to the other and for the other, wrote Lévinas, but no one belongs to anyone, no more than we belong to ourselves, as psychotics often recall in their violent and astonishing entirety.

Our incurable experiences of the other's infidelity take us back to the primary tearing apart of the world that occurs after birth in which the separation from the mother and then her absence are imposed for the first time. When does a nursling understand that she will no longer be "one/two" or even indissolubly "with"—within the fetal fusion that was her life up to this point—and that, from then on, a certain solitude will arm her days and nights? What does she do with this knowledge? How does she transmute this impotence (to make the other come closer to her, continuously) into a desire for solitude? For, precisely, this incurable wound is fertile with the possibility of any future amorous attachment. When does infidelity begin? With an idea, a kiss, nudity, or a clandestine life? Doesn't it rather begin as soon as it is represented, as soon as a thought of the other insinuates itself within you in nearest proximity to your soul and your desiring body? No matter what you do with this thought and this body, it never leaves you and will live its own life and death, and won't necessarily coincide with your acts or your will (many loves die before separation or resist it, going well beyond—with a sort of animal life of their own). But our fidelities, for their part, haunt us like so many imperatives whose purpose we ignore while we bend to them as if our lives depended on it. Confronted with this categorical imperative, we must invent true infidelities—open, fervent, fertile lines of flight like those that Kerouac speaks of in *On the Road*,[2] an immense metaphorical text about a wholly other freedom than that of travel. And thus, taming our own necessary infidelity, we will perhaps discern in it a traversal that is not only betrayal but rather a manner of getting lost in nearest proximity to yourself.

What is truly incurable is fidelity.

Zero Risk?

In a society where insurance is imposed on us in every domain, because no one is allowed to decline coverage anymore or simply make do without it, it has become useless to promote zero risk; it is a matter of course. Zero risk has become the obligatory horizon of our collective and individual decisions. A little money is all insurance seems to demand for itself to protect us against the occurrence of any type of accident. In reality, our perception of reality has been, as we say these days, reformatted. In her remarkable book *The Test Drive*, Avital Ronell recalls that the category of the test is universal. Humans, throughout history, have put at risk their freedom, their reason, their courage, and their limits, to the point of conceiving the Test itself as the force behind courage. The necessity to be insured only expanded in proportion to the logic of self-evaluation and the "testability" of things and beings.

The zero risk we end up with is deadly. It strips the subject of responsibility for her acts; it divides her from within into a being of the drive who risks anything and everything, a being who therefore must be protected by consent or by force against herself, and a being of reason who is never sufficiently reasonable. She is thus potentially a deviant or on the way to

becoming a pathogenic individual. It is strange to think that no era has ever been more "secure" than ours and that nonetheless we all suffer from an ever growing disquiet that is incommensurable with any event, or I should say, any risk of an event. In the future, no doubt, we will be weighed down by genocides committed in wars so radically dehumanizing that, as of yet, they are inconceivable. Zero risk—in armed or diplomatic conflicts, or even in conflicts of interest between industrialized powers—tends, in contemporary wars, to be imposed as an ethical law. It's taken for granted that no one wants to "risk" losing human lives; war, from now on, should paradoxically be able to do without death. No longer allowing for death as a possibility or as a strategy, but only in terms of the necessity to avoid it, the first belligerent who agrees to go beyond this "zero risk" will prevail. It is kamikaze logic. You want to fight? Go ahead, put your life at risk. Hegel elaborated this logic a long time ago, but no doubt he hadn't anticipated the barbarism of our "clean" contemporary wars whose so-called "collateral" damage will henceforth entail more dead among the civilian population than the ranks of the military.

What remains, then . . . is a very narrow margin, empty space, time for nothing. Just sign, right there, on the dotted line as expected. For don't forget that your options aren't only about you but others as well. Risk is an outdated romanticism for adults who refuse to grow up, to assume their share of responsibility and compliantly entrust it to others who, in turn, will proceed to capitalize on it and save you from your own recklessness. Nor will delinquents the world over tell you otherwise, they who are summarily criminalized, in spite of their economic distress, the lack of education, the mismanagement of social services, plain ignorance, the defunding of schools, and the collapse of what's called order. Indeed, as Foucault describes so well, others impugn these delinquents in order to remind us every day what we have escaped. Nowhere are delinquents accepted anymore except in the highest echelons of the State, where they arrogate the privilege to be beyond laws and rights. The law has proliferated with so many edicts, amendments, and decrees of every kind that no jurist, qualified as she may be, could claim comprehensive expertise. All she can do is *interpret the law*. Cynicism and denunciation are de rigueur, tempered by a serenade of noble sentiments whose only value is that they go unquestioned. In our climate of ballyhooed economic austerity and political torpor, the prime necessity is to ensure against risks that, in concentric circles, domestic or planetary, create an atmosphere of diffuse fear and distilled anxiety for which we have no one to incriminate but ourselves, always underinsured.

The very utterance of zero risk is an absurdity because its actuality would annul the very reality of which it attempts to speak.

Peril must be faced head-on. This is the least among the forms of courage that might save us. We can always recover from pain, catastrophe, or mourning, but evil will always claim a share. We will never be saved in advance.

How (Not) to Become Oneself . . .

There is a profusion of books, seemingly, whose purpose is to show us the best way to "become oneself" and how to reach that goal. The *how-to* manuals that have met with such success on the other side of the Atlantic and now here in France as well (How to be happy? How to succeed in life? How to find happiness?) fuel the global market in re-assurance. The formulations designed to attract clients might change, but the discourse hardly does. Almost always such books deal with this gratifying search for self-realization—that is, the blossoming that neither you nor I will ever attain but that we all seem to expect from existence as manna from heaven.

But what does it mean, in reality, "to become oneself"? Aren't we already burdened enough with ourselves to look for yet another secret idyll with this fictive character that one keeps trying to know better? Doesn't it come down, once again, to the question: Do you love me? Unable to exist enough for others, we must recognize ourselves . . . Inclined to doubt and fragility, values today stigmatized as negative, we are offered teaching, courses and seminars in self-reeducation. Even psychoanalysis lends itself to such a project, although in more glorious times (I mean in less faint-hearted times) it would have refused to support the artificial construction

of narcissism, judging that the world already has more than enough of it, and that those who complain about their meager self-assurance have more than others.

Immanence is a concept without object because it includes, in advance, the whole of the given. It is a horizon line, at the junction of heaven and earth, a mute line that invites our gaze to reach beyond. The necessity for transcendence is undoubtedly the surest mark of the immanence of this world, of its very materiality, the imprint of its profuse prodigality. We move about in the face of events that infinitely exceed us, not because they come from a hither world, or an other world, but rather because they come together and apart without our help, like big animals at play; like ciphers that never cease to overflow the visible from all sides, to inform it, to give it form, image, and time; like the cinema that inscribes an inverted image, albeit in real time, of lives that might be our own. An event has its own density. When it happens, it is above and beyond—that is, without any place set aside for it within the skein of the real; and the occurrence of this pure accident creates a new life. Sometimes, the event anticipates the movement of an entire people; sometimes, as well, it creates something shared, a veritable communism of thought, together with the resolution to live rather than to die, to make die, or to let oneself die. To take the risk of immanence, wouldn't this mean that you begin to give up becoming yourself? In the sense in which this "self," which we are supposed to have recognized at any price and loved better, is still and always remains an imaginary projection born of our attachments, our fears, and our expectations . . . The most powerful experiences that we are given to live dissolve the "self" more than any negative resolution. Within the enlarged perception of the instant and of the world, within the instantaneous joy that they infuse, within the inner upheaval and the alleviation of all anxiety that they provoke, there arises a strange reconciliation, as if the real no longer offered any opposition.

We want insouciance at the expense of servitude. And without having to think such servitude. Psychoanalysis has attempted, for its part, to explore it—at least the pioneers did, Rivers, Freud, Ferenczi, Tausk, Lacan, Winnicott, and a few others: they reminded us that we are the inheritors of a history that traversed us but whose origin remained unknown; that we were infused with desires we would prefer to know nothing about, with obsolete and comforting ideals, and with a baby's skin turned upward to the firmament of adults, wrapped around our hearts up to the instant of our death; and that, in addition, we *wanted* all of it . . . We drank it in with delectation and imagination, and sometimes fanaticism. Whereas we never

cease to forget and to receive untimely reminders of our being mortal. To admit that we can do something other than be victims of circumstance, not because chance wouldn't exist (which is magical or religious thinking), nor because the real would no longer break into our lives, but rather because the manner in which we let it infringe upon us, no matter the degree of its gravity, or even ferocity, depends on us and our manner of negotiating an open, moving, accident-strewn, and, in a certain respect, unrepresentable world . . .

And what if you made an effort "not to get hung up on yourself," to throw every familiar thing overboard, and to enter into non–self-conformity? To break things off, but through a modification of your own internal, subjective chemistry? A vertiginous descent toward the place where I am no longer "me," dissolved, confused with perception itself, a psychic space become night, rock, and space, the echo of an animal in the distance, claw marks on the ground. Traces of self, unrecognizable, hacked up, without possible translation. To this end, to self-desist (and not to regain yourself)—that is, *to get lost*. "Getting lost," writes Adam Phillips, "is the best defense against the feeling of being lost, in part because we have the impression that the problem is within our grasp, as it were . . . You get lost because you are not lost. So we can say: we are lost when there is no object of desire; and we make ourselves lost when there is an object of desire."[1] All of the fundamental experiences of our being—including, and perhaps above all, joy—cannot be contained within the boundaries of what we could define, even in a vague manner, as "self"; they make coexist states of the world and subjective perceptions, but also pieces of the body, images, representations, and affects. To take the risk of immanence is to refuse any hither world, as Nietzsche insisted, to bet only on this world, which infinitely exceeds our perception. Sometimes, *not becoming yourself* is precisely like not dying, not being already locked in a strait jacket—existence, identity, or rule of life, which serve as reference points, as a fragile enclave where the ego perdures. "We will say of pure immanence that it is A LIFE, and nothing else," writes Gilles Deleuze. "It is not immanence to life, but the immanent that is in nothing is itself a life. A life is the immanence of immanence, absolute immanence: it is complete power, complete beatitude."[2]

Being in Secret

In what sense is the secret a risk? The secret is much more than something kept. It is also an essential dimension of being because it allows the heart to fortify itself, to welcome this inviolable "heart of hearts" [*for intérieur*] A body can be tortured; your eyes can be scanned by a lie detector; you can be hypnotized; but it will never be possible to force entry into the secret of your soul. Torturers know it well. Even during the Inquisition, the condemned could refuse to talk by invoking the "heart of hearts" [*for intérieur*]. The door of the heart would not be open. The mystics have given us the most beautiful pages on the *secret heart*. In French, to be "au secret" means to be consigned to a dungeon, a place of the most radical withdrawal of the living before death. The capacity to keep a secret is an aptitude to resist power. This is the political and spiritual dimension that, in these times when we are told to reveal everything, it is perhaps important to defend.

Truth is an exit from the crypt, a laying bare. Can everything be unveiled? Must we tell everything to the other? What is the relation between truth and the secret? The secret does not exist without the possibility of being shared, without the word that defends it or that betrays it, without the promise to keep it, without the confession that unravels it. If the secret

touches on all the facets of the human experience, there exist, in history, at least two domains where—as a discourse—it will have served a dominant function: sex and prayer. Sexuality is a sphere in which intimate discourse plays a central role. What goes unspoken has no other function than to underscore the gap between what is said and what could be said. The erotic is a function of the secret that reaches into language. The other dimension of intimate silent language is prayer. Invocation, meditation, hope: all the forms of inner religious discourse betoken a secret shared exclusively with God. Today, however, this token has no currency. Sex and prayer, to take only these two examples of internalized discourse that essentially belong to silence and the secret, were radically "exposed" during the last century. Perhaps it's time to recall their essential complicity.

Prayer is a state of waiting for a word that you know will not come, but that, at the same time, is there inside you, deposited there from time immemorial. Speech is linked to this lack of the other, this absent other who does not respond, who will not respond, who doesn't know and yet welcomes your voice unlike any other, in the absolute opening to the unhoped-for. Does another similar space exist? You need only believe that an other might hear you, with the most intense hope against the background of night, such a paradox . . .

What space exists today to risk the secret, not the "miserable little pile of secrets" of occulted vices or jealous possessiveness, nor the political secret, I mean the secret that must transpire between self and self—the density of an infrangible night?

The secret is the other side of shame.

Befriending Our Fears

We live in fear without knowing it. We are surrounded by fear as by a ghostly presence, an apparition. Fear unsettles and bewilders us, and yet . . . why not risk befriending it just as, at night, we approach certain large animals? Going right out, and at night, to meet it. We believe that our fears hold us back; we believe we don't have enough strength to confront them, because this would be to know them, but also to love them, even to grow attached to them. Our fears present the face of our future amazement, the beginning of all creation. They are the crystallized scraps of our tiniest emotions just beyond our fingertips; we let them slip away, then regret not keeping them. We confront our fears and, silently, we are held back inwardly by the memory of ancient hopes. We live under local anesthesia, wrapped in cellophane, desperately seeking the substance, or the love, which might wake us up without frightening us.

We are caught up in the wrong war, lost soldiers fighting for a forgotten cause. The desperate cause, always so urgent, of childhood. The pure perfection of childhood whose very wounds make us feel nostalgic. Then our first terrors were invented, our first drawings of ogres and heavens, sleepless nights armed with promises that won't be kept but that we will claim as our

due for years on end without anyone able to do anything about it, not even the attentive psychoanalyst who listens without interrupting you, for years on end, from whom the path of white pebbles eroded by wind, birds, solitude, and forgetting, also slips away. The mystery is that it never leaves us. The territory delimited, very precisely, by our fears. To take the risk of being afraid in order, finally, to enter this territory, to dissolve into it, to dive into the river and, holding your breath, to reach the bright stones on the bottom and to bring them up to the surface where they won't have the same sheen or mystery, and to observe them up close, brushing them with a fingertip. Where do you come from? What is your name? What do you want from me? One is afraid of being abandoned, betrayed, afraid of not being loved anymore, of not being capable of love anymore, afraid of being cold, hungry, sick, or alone, afraid that life will pass and nothing will have happened. Fear enfolds each event as if to protect its chrysalis, eventually unfurling all the words that circulate for holding, for making bend, for sex, for the momentary impulse, for treasure believed lost, for betrayal, for making suffer, for loving, for creating. At odds with time, almost at odds with life, leaning on terror and standing against it, how to keep your eyes open, just a little longer . . . how not to remain at a remove from the most beautiful things?

"My heart, she says, is dismembered. I am a terrorized child, in pieces. I never take a plane or a train; I don't sleep; I don't swim in deep water; I avoid crowds. I am on hiatus. I exist within a somnambulistic fear that cramps my movements, inhibits my desire, asphyxiates my life. I am afraid of you as well, and of wasting my time here, of unreasonably expecting that something will happen . . ."

"You are afraid . . . here, now?"

I look at her attentively, my gaze never leaving her body, like a fisherman when the fly on his line drops very gently on the ripples of the water.

"Yes, I want to run away, never to have come."

The silence spreads out for a long time, a bright calming fire, and then little by little I sense her breathing otherwise.

"And what if you loved your fear . . ." I risked, barely a question.

"This horrible fear is suffocating, you don't understand, that's clear . . . I can't say anything about it, only flee from it, think about it as little as possible. Curl up in a ball when it comes and wait. As a little girl, already, this is what I'd do in my room . . ."

I repeated: "And what if perhaps you love it?" This is all I said, that perhaps, indeed, you love it . . .

She turned her head toward the window. The curtains let in a filtered, meager light. The silence took on the quality that it gets from surprise, or at least from something that slips into the rhythm of the dialogue, at the split second when the response is lodged exactly where the other is waiting for it, expecting its arrival.

"What if, perhaps, I loved it?" she repeats.

Words, when they are repeated, sometimes assume a talismanic value, as if reprise conferred on them an unparalleled power, a sort of internalization of their power to name the world. With this mere repetition, simple as a child's rhyme, fear became embodied, a vector of desire, at once distant and incorporated. It became thinkable, a very gentle surface of projection that might uphold the word: love.

"Why would I love it since it prevents everything, including putting an end to my stupid little life?"

All of a sudden, she glimpsed the infinite power invested in the fear she donned in order to stay still, curled up in a ball, waiting for someone to come looking for her. Her mother or some other person who would deign to love her. Poor hidden thing, no voice or body or desire, just a ready alibi.

"Why?" she says. "You know why, so tell me . . ."

"There is no why . . ."

There is a certain lassitude in my response. No why . . . no. We so much want that to be it, a key memory that surges up again and makes it all come together, a single word, an event such as the tiny pea in the fairy tale that keeps the princess from sleeping. But the why remains a bluff, a rearview mirror in the blind spot. There is only the how, Kierkegaard said, the specific manner whereby we invented a path to the event of love, of fear, of death, or of the effraction of beauty within us, along with many other fugitive bewilderments that we have trouble recovering from. I decided to talk to her, to deal with her fear as best as I could . . .

"This fear that you shelter within you is perhaps, who knows, your sole refuge, or perhaps you have believed in it for so long that it's now difficult to mourn it. It is painful to renounce renunciation because, from the instant you do, you realize that the damage has been done, that time has been lost, that blindness and alibis and the poverty of self-deception are gone as well. When blood returns to nearly frozen limbs, a terrible pain sets in that makes you long for the deadly anesthesia of the cold; you wish never to have had to awaken. To welcome fear is also to welcome the possibility of joy, the effraction of alterity, of the unknown, and of the living; it is to leave renunciation behind and this is what's terrible. Fear protects us from such a risk like an anxious, unhappy mother, whom you will never appease."

"You are sending me back into unhappiness . . ."

There was a blankness to her voice infinitely vaster that any sadness. I leaned forward, toward her, surprised by wanting to embrace her, to take her hands in mine like you would do with a child who is grieving but doesn't know it yet. I would have liked to be able to imagine that my words touch her, reach her.

"I am sending you back to the place of your unhappiness, yes, perhaps, you'd know better than me, I am sending you back there as to a deadly shelter you still believe it impossible to distance yourself from, to free yourself from. The point is not to prove you wrong . . ."

"Forget my heart, forget my head, forget my reason, forget my fear, forget my words, forget my childhood terror, but keep me close to you."

"I will not replace your fear, I will not guard you against it, I can only listen to you, and with you, very gently, wait for the strange chrysalis of your fear to sprout colorful wings, delicate and shimmery, suffused with light. In Greek, the name for this butterfly is psychè."

She stood. Time was up. She staggered as if the room was listing slightly. "It will pass . . . I have vertigo, it happens often, I don't even notice anymore."

I helped her to regain balance.

"You never say sorry," she said.

"Yes I do, it happens like your dizzy spells. I say sorry, my mistake, apologies."

"But you are sure you're right . . ."

"I am neither right nor wrong, just as there was no why, it is what is happening at this moment that might change everything, in a second, in your life and in mine as well, because we are in each other's presence and it's an event that, if we are there for it, if we accept being there, is absolutely overwhelming, like any encounter."

"You don't have the right to speak that way, you are an analyst."

"If analysis is not an encounter, what is it? A pact? An alliance? Yes, that too, an alliance with whoever in you no longer wishes to love this fear to death, to die of it on your feet, upright like a soldier at the front; and also with whoever wants to leave and feels dizzy. I am just saying that this fear is the same as your desire, the very same, and that you are right to love it because there where it is, your desire is as well."

"I don't understand a thing."

"Yes, I believe you do, and that is even why you are here." I went to look for a book and handed it to her. It is one of the few talismans against fear that I know of . . ."

She lingered on the cover and smiled at the title. "Thank you," she said. "Most likely I won't be back, but I will keep it." Then she bent down to cross the threshold, the low door, and made her way down the stairs. Another person was waiting to be let in. I was running late, nighttime already.

A fear does not come undone; it coexists with a perception of the world to which it adheres, indissolubly. Each of our voyages, our attempts to escape from boredom, everydayness, the same on an indefinite loop, sustains a relation with fear that, at the exact place of the heart, the heart that remembers, digs a front line. What appears in our fears are the disparate pieces of a puzzle, which potentially contains what haunted us, disappointed us, made us dream, or totter, what constituted in filigree a possible world for us. To take the risk of our fears, then, is perhaps simply to tame their naked voice and, like children do with the menacing darkness that surrounds sleep, to tell ourselves stories, knowing that for each fright there is a tiny magic spell, a fugitive talisman as limpid as a Bach cantata.

At the Risk of Being Sad

Sadness leaves us caught between two worlds. Neither despair nor indifference, it is a stroll on the edge of catastrophe, but with elegance, like a child running along a cliff with no awareness of danger, eyes on shards of blue sky, the design of the clouds, the gentleness of the wind. Sadness has no density of its own, no echo. It delimits a shifting, unreasonable, internal space where you are always both on the verge of tears and of a strange appeasement. Sadness can engulf but also calm; it possesses an enveloping power that swathes the body with a cottony feeling of strangeness to itself, like a heartbreak that suddenly deprives one of sense, but not nostalgia. Sadness is unproductive, we are told, which is (also) why it is condemned.

What is sadness good for? Not a true cathartic outburst (into the bargain), not angry or transgressive, it has an unassailable gentleness that is unsettling. And yet it is fecund, make no mistake, but not in an organized or stable fashion. It detaches, it harbors a subtle force of unbinding; but it is in the meshwork of broken links, of disparate thoughts, quietly disheartening emotions, that true thinking appears. What I mean is an other, unrecognizable thinking—the thinking of mad love, for example, or of the

future, like a stroke of lightning that you see flare up on the horizon and then disappear. A restless (that is, philosophical) thinking or a vision, who knows, something that takes form in space before your eyes and that you can suddenly transcribe with ease—something obvious.

Sadness has in common with forgiveness that it bears upon an unknown fault, an intolerable act, an offense, applies a balm that, at the same time, reignites pain. Sadness appeases what, at the same time, it sharpens like the blade of a samurai. Nothing more acute or less certain. Sadness clears the slate of time, the tranquil expanse of time, and gathers it back up in the form of pointy little stones and rubs them together, which makes a bizarre music; the past reemerges mingled with tiny instants of life that would otherwise be forgotten. Mingled with sadness, this patchwork of time is not merely nostalgic, even if sadness is often accompanied by this combined feeling of regret and expectation toward our own past. It is also a folded time, bundled upon itself, with its own throughline, its own echo chambers parallel to ours. Sadness is not tragic; it spaces drama out as landscape; it diffracts pain to make it bearable, scatters it into several points of the body and soul. Sadness is never entirely one's own, which is what makes it a rare object. Felt by oneself, it does not belong to us; it never manages fully to sink into us; and this gap is precisely what binds us to it. You are sad about never having dared to give your name to that woman you talked to for a few minutes and whose beauty, five years later, still overwhelms you; you are sad about missing an important meeting, about being forgotten, about no longer loving, about going by the wayside, about being in exile. You are sad as you would be in the solitude of a foreign land when no familiar things lull your gaze. There is a cruelty to sadness because of its limitless expanse, the impossibility of assigning it a threshold, of deciding when it ends. But the moment when sadness has finally released you is ungraspable, like sand. The sadness has left you, that's all there is to it. And you write, you love, you dream, and you fall asleep with loose arms and a clenched heart; sadness will have left you free, but different. Whence its risk. You can avoid it, cut yourself off from it, step away from it, or ignore it. Or else you can take the risk of sadness and open yourself to the inner exile to which it subjects you without violence, impossible to imagine beforehand. And in this unmapped and unmarked territory, you can linger awhile . . .

Sadness is very close to fatigue, this contemporary illness. Fatigue is a vital process, Blanchot said. It is a state of being on the outskirts of yourself that, in a certain manner, steps in to take the illness of life upon itself. It arranges things for you as well, providing a ready excuse: "I am tired"; and

in the withdrawal that it authorizes, its underlying gravity escapes you, so that it becomes almost intangible and ultimately incurable. By sparing us the need to recognize an even deeper illness, fatigue is a capricious affect that is liable to take bodily form in an instant and never let go, opposing our life force with unbearable resistance, and denying us access to the world of healthy people who never seem to get exhausted. Fatigue bears a foretaste of melancholy that is attributed to stress, lack of sleep, or time for oneself, all things that we could easily bear in the throes of amorous effervescence. Fatigue levies the "for itself" that seems so lacking today, feeding the ogre (work, family, and so on). Here we are by the sandbox, grown up too quickly, and alone. Without imagination to persuade us that anyone is waiting for us. Fatigue makes imperceptible the pain, although acute, of not being recognized. It is difficult to give up waiting for recognition, to deliver yourself from it except by distributing it among the shallow friendships crammed into impossible schedules and long "vacations." To gain access to sadness, then, is to delve into the truth of this fatigue. To extract its active or vital principle, its urgency.

To take the risk of sadness would be the opposite of entering into melancholy; it would be to understand that sadness is the secret underside of beatitude, and of the enlargement of being unto which it beckons us, makes us remember another possibility of being toward ourselves and in the world, in hospitality to what comes.

At the Risk of Being Free

To philosophize is to trace freedom back to what lies before it.

—EMMANUEL LÉVINAS, *Totality and Infinity*

Freedom is undoubtedly the most banal among the usual ways of understanding risk. Who doesn't desire more freedom, to move in a vaster space, to open everyday life to the unexpected? Who wouldn't wish to be delivered from constraints? In an existence besieged with obligations, prey to all sorts of stress and pressure, who wouldn't want to have a voyager's latitude? And yet, whether freedom is an object of desire, nothing is less certain . . . Freedom is a movement of emancipation, not a stable state. It supposes that we become conscious of our shackles, of what holds us back like Monsieur Seguin's goat, penned up—with our consent, to boot—in our fantasies. On this score, psychoanalysis is unequivocal. Freedom is almost always illusory; it relies on the multiple conditions of our desire, our education, our culture, our world; it is rooted in an ideology that offers the subject only a beautiful escape route . . . into an extremely cramped space. The space of a sequestered self who willingly arranges for its own surveillance.

What would a "self" do who wasn't bolted shut from the inside? Our capacity to act takes into account, at each instant of our lives, an unbelievable number of parameters, certain of them conscious, others less so. To risk more freedom is necessarily to leave something behind, a quietude, a

community, a familiar world that offers, many frustrations certainly, but also solid points of reference, footholds. Does freedom teach us anything? Perhaps not. It demands that we risk our desire as if it were something infinitely precious, a unique event, an imperious voice—that, in sum, we go out ahead of ourselves, go where we didn't know we are, where something unknown to us yet speaks of us and convokes us. Freedom is a convocation. But how do we respond when it can't be willed or its outcome hastened? Perhaps it's a disposition of being—or an "inclination," to use the lovely expression from the seventeenth century—a disposition to the right moment, a *kairos*, to the intensity that designates the moment when we are utterly and truly alive. What is called chance, or destiny, is undoubtedly but one possible interpretation of this intensity of presence to others and to the event. For freedom hails us from the greatest distance (seemingly) from ourselves; it puts up very little resistance to our objections, takes leave of us, and disappears. It arises like a blind spot in a rearview mirror, so that you must turn around to see what's back there. But nothing in the annals of our past corresponds to it; no more codes of conduct here, no more heritage, only the raw future yet to be written. Fears above all are what precede us, far ahead of our acts. Depression is just another name for this refusal of freedom or, more precisely, for the radical impossibility, unbeknownst to us, of believing that any liberation is possible, any emancipation from the "objective" limits upon our existence. What divides within us, here, is the field of an endless battle because the risk of being free touches upon the most ancient loyalties that we carry; our armor on this battlefront isn't of our own making but that of other generations, other memories.

Is freedom exercised at the risk of truth? To think freedom in terms of subjective will is to discount everything from well before our birth that forbids it, forgotten oaths, coerced promises, unburied dead, meager and violent secrets. To take the risk of being free is to make the Pascalian wager that freedom will be discovered to the extent that we venture out to sea. The boat that carries Virgil and his friend into Hell restores its passengers to their exilic condition as human beings, for only at such a price, Dante tells us, will they be witnesses to what they have risked as subjects—namely, the truth. "The distinction between free and non-free," writes Lévinas, "would not be the ultimate distinction between humanity and inhumanity, nor the ultimate mark of sense and nonsense . . . Has not the Good chosen the subject with an election recognizable in the responsibility of being hostage, to which the subject is destined, which he cannot evade without denying himself, and by virtue of which he is unique?"[1] Herein we recognize the ethics of Lévinas according to which the Good comes before

Being and in the infinite responsibility of the subject for the other, which alone founds the (finite) possibility of her freedom.

The freedom to act is but infinitesimal in relation to the freedom of being, which is what properly constitutes our humanity. Under terror and torture, each human being remains free to the bitter end to risk her truth—that is, something that no one will ever be able to take by force. Because the human is a spiritual being, this freedom, which founds her in turn, she alone can abdicate it. If the human and the inhuman diverge along the lines of a humanity in which the relation to the other, never risked enough, folds into pure suffering, what do we make of this surfeit of freedom? Will we sacrifice again and always more to our rapacious appetite for power and technological mastery? Or will we have the audacity to take within ourselves the responsibility for a difficult freedom that can be risked only to the extent that it's in danger?

The Time They Call Lost

Time, inconsiderately, is as difficult to think as to experience as such. Constituted in the imaginary but arming the most unrepresentable real, it convokes us to an impossible figuration. The time that we eternally seek to make our own, to recapture, seems never to stop defying our expectations. True time is never anything but lost. Diverted, destroyed, detached, fragmented, or even indefinitely deferred, time lost is of no use. It gets lost in us just as in the acts that it will not anchor. Decision, choice, function: everything happens in detached bits and pieces, nothing remains but an indecisive stretch of time on the threshold of which we exist. We revolve around our lives in the oscillating rhythm of more or less fictional schedules, overfilled by the real but also by the impossibility in which we exist, from birth, to be on time. Time took nine months to fashion us, without us—that is, without anything for us to do, to decide, or to vanquish—nine months of wrapping our fibers with time, of our being in becoming, of our nascent, not yet subjective freedom . . . What to do with this time from before our history as subjects?

We like to say: I gained time, as if such a gain could satisfy us, delivering us into a sort of economy without money or exchange, gained from

a nonquantifiable surplus of life that would amount to a supplement of being . . . This imaginary gain is distilled everywhere, but unnoticed, making us believe that we have a surfeit of desire at our disposal. Propelled into activities, the accumulation of goods, and the busyness of urban life at multiple rhythms and counter-rhythms, we imperceptibly lose touch with ourselves. At odds with the movement of interiority that opens our ears, the floating attention that is not only to be had in an analyst's office but also in existence, and that, close to meditation, would be a manner of envisaging the real without violence while letting it affect us. In this movement, time is indeed lost. Inevitably so—lost in flânerie, boredom, and insomnia, all of the intervals that serve no purpose and yet translate into states of being, into disquiet, at times into aimless wandering. Familiar strangeness, *Unheimlichkeit*, temporal translation of the copresence of a mother both vertiginously close and faraway. The close and the faraway here serve as an initial measure (or immeasure) to express the irresolute temporality that fabricates our relation to the world, to inner time, and to finitude. Does losing time merely mean accepting that we never had it to lose but had always been within it as within a time before time, within a genesis that wouldn't yet belong to the history to which we are returned, for example, by trauma but also jouissance? Such a risk obliges us to think the possibility of being "without outside," perhaps what Rilke called the Open.

There will never be a way to recover from being born of an other and yet being alone, having to die alone; between these two enters an impossible dialogue that fabricates a time that is literally, as Maurice Blanchot wrote, impossible: "Prophetic speech announces an impossible future, or makes the future it announces, because it announces it, something impossible, a future one would not know how to live and that must upset all the sure givens of existence."[1] This impossible future, however, is that which speech affords us, and which links us. To lose time is thus perhaps to attach ourselves to the fetal "outside of time" when we were two, one in two, two in one, memory, affects, and sensations, linked indissolubly to the Other who carries and nourishes us (the mother, but also language), and this outside of time that will always resonate within us because it is matrix of our being, spirit, and body. "Time has more than one dimension," Elie During writes. "It is not a form of interiority because it is what, on the contrary, envelops us. Time cannot be inside of us, far from it, because it is we who inhabit time; it is we who move within it as a virtual milieu in whose obscure depths coexist all the degrees of duration."[2] To wander randomly, to get lost even in a city that you know well, to make time for a conversation that never stops coming together and falling apart, to forget all about an

appointment, to stay up until morning, to be reconciled for a time with our ghosts—such are the moments that we extract from the economy of bonds that we wish to keep as regular as our schedules; and this grueling inability to manage time imperceptibly sends us back to early childhood, to the time of play and awakening, of building forts and crazy laughter, and of disquiet as well, when time strains the confines of the day, in an ungraspable projection of duration. What does tomorrow mean when you are only a few months old? Tomorrow and yesterday are continents where the promise, "I'll be right back," is the only fixed point (the voice, invocation) that makes sense for the child, giving her the strength to wait and make of this waiting time into a refuge, a chamber of dreams and writing whence she can, like Victor Ségalen, explore the world.

Dead Alive

Death and life tear apart from one another like silence and thunder.

—GEORGES BATAILLE, *Les Mangeurs d'étoiles*

No one wants to die anymore. Formerly obvious, everywhere present, death has become a scandal. It is an unacceptable affront to our effort to find a cure, or eternal youth, and to access the instantaneity of virtual and fantasy worlds. Death is a thing that shouldn't encumber us any longer, that we hide and avoid. The dead, today, go up in industrial smoke, without ceremony or ritual, or only with shoddy ceremonies that hardly seem worth the effort. Soon, there will be no cemeteries left, too much useless space. The economy of death resides in so-called life insurance and in the funeral industry: leave it to the professionals, you will get a reasonable mourning period, three or four months for next of kin, any more would be indecent, any less shocking.

To risk not dying, then, how is it a risk and not the most widespread fantasy in Western society? For, dead we are, quite often . . . Dead of a quiet little death—obvious, even charming, a death that includes a garden and a landscape, diverse amusements and pleasures, nothing easier, everything will be provided as long as you consent to it: oh yes, all that's required is your soul, but no, there will be no Faustian bargain. The devil has left the building; he has lost interest. Since what torments you is life, get used to

the fact, give yourself a little peace at last, sign right here, Hell won't be a problem, we take care of the rest. Children, life stress, sex and love, hand it all off, lighten your load, sign out for awhile, let your yourself go, dying amidst your life is not such a bad thing, you'll see . . .

To take the risk of not dying might resemble Micro-Miniscule Almost Undetectable Refusals. Even if there is a pill to replace complaint, avidity, and anxiety, straining the limits of illusion and expectation—and just like that, thanks to this sophisticated biology (antidepressants, morphine, anxiolytics, hashish, or other drug therapies), no more boredom, frustration, envy, or feelings of isolation—you will be granted what the misrecognition of your desire, in the end, still allows you to grasp. No, in fact, there is no object that will bring an end to your hunger and your tears. No object will give you back a desiring body. And whatever substance you swallow—because, here is another (object, drug, artifact) and another. . . you will gradually forget what you were waiting for, your desire will get lost in the web of a world taken over by readymade operants and performance enhancers . . . Why persist? You need only lay down your weapons, elaborate gestures and pretexts, misunderstandings and excuses, very quietly follow your path without fury or freedom, without sharp edges, shadow, or light. Almost nothing will be asked of you. Even sex will no longer be a problem. And if the pain of living remains—for, ultimately, you will be clinically alive—there are other somniferants to vanquish your last scruples, your persistent anxieties, whence you will find deliverance, no attachments left, merely bonds as light as champagne bubbles.

You will be enshrouded alive, asleep in light tombs. You will lie there, yes, allowing the world to offer you the ugliest, most grotesque, unstable, and vulgar objects, the right ideals in response to your appetites. What does it matter? Deracinated, disinvested, you wander without compass or territory, tethered by nothing but an artificial fixity—work, family, religion—which includes the clandestine side of your story, walking the same walks, at the same hours. How to disembalm already dead bodies, formatted minds, while forgetting that it's possible to invent a life of desire and joy? The risks are serious—collapse, vertigo, isolation, rejection, even open hostility. No one likes to be reminded that freedom is right there, right away, ready for the taking. Not tomorrow, not elsewhere, here and now. Or to recall that we are the first to dig our own graves . . . Reread Kierkegaard. Our migraines prevent us from thinking that, already in the midst of life, we are wound in a sheet. We are entering an era of gentle glaciation, continuous light anesthesia with organized leisure, administered

thinking, life in bits, more objects to numb us, to prevent, from one instant to the next, any feeling of wonder, any step aside, or step back.

The obsessional neurotic reminds us every day of all of this. What a perfect patient! With a velvety voice and steady gait, he plays the loyal butler who ushers you with utter quietude into Bluebeard's castle and the chambers of horrors that it conceals. He will come to you, a little obsequiously, of course, but sure of his right to be cured. Might betray a hint of irony, just to see whom he's dealing with. And so the analysis will go, always on time. Attempting to seize control of the frame through the use of reason and to manipulate the transference, he will point from afar to the chaos that inhabits him, obliging you to bear witness to your own impotence along with his. A clock in apparent working order but with a faulty mechanism, he invites you to stand by and watch with him as time passes on the way to death. Smooth and unbreakable on the outside, devastated within. The obsessional neurotic has constructed a few refuges, hobbyhorses, and routines that he is willing to share so long as you don't tamper with them. He tells you that he is already dead and wants you to raise him from the tomb without changing a thing about his existence. He will keep pretending to be alive all the time. At times, he might even be eccentric, but he alone knows what crypt withholds his sense of festivity and friendship. To disentangle him from death is no easy task for the analyst that you will be led to be. I say led to be because you must invent a path not found in any guide.

History is frozen, time as well. There is no reprieve. Now or never. Tomorrow is not the beginning. The more people grasp this fact, the more they sink into melancholy before our eyes. As if existence were solely a question of accepting renunciation without sacrifice, without heroism or sublime cause, whatever the price. The obsessional neurotic encloses within the vice grip of surveillance the vital force that threatens the equilibrium that he has patiently constructed in order to avoid a nameless anxiety. Risk is the untimely baring of ancient wounds, without fortified archives where memory abides. These memories that now seem to belong only from a great distance to the one who suffers from "non-life" remain no less suffocating. The temptation, for the analyst, when faced with people embalmed alive, is to alert them that waiting is over, now is the emergency, no time is left. But she must avoid falling for their panic, and for the criers of tempest and disaster whom they echo, knowing full well that arming themselves with fear never makes them any freer. You probably have to travel back in time, return to the wild afternoons at ten years old—to your first

ambushes, your first hard knocks. Your secrets wrapped in scraps of paper. To venture back to the impalpable night of childhood that makes you weep noiselessly. To take images of little bits of life and put them together one by one, slow-motion vibrations: seesaw, betrayal, falling, slight vertigo, a juxtaposition of the unhitched certainties of the real. At the finish, almost nothing is left to hold onto, a handful of memories, a few places, two or three first names—somewhere among them your own name, softly whispered. This name doesn't belong to you; you don't know it. It founds you and traverses you. Some call it the unconscious. Others don't believe in it at all. You think that you might have glimpsed it, but it is what holds you fast. To know anything about it, you must tread step by step back into the realm of the dead. Traverse where there is no registered territory, where no maps are permitted, no passports, and no excuses. In order to return from death to life, quit the loop of obsession and the permanent surveillance of the inner eye that never quits he who suffers from anxiety, and go down and cross paths with souls for whom no one weeps.

Once back, we discover here, in this darkness peopled by the dead, something to put our faith in. Something in the face of which courage has a meaning. Desire comes from a very pure, enchanted form of wonder unhampered by terror. All of a sudden it opens up within us. Numbers, a piece of music, a chord, a light, a skin, or the taste of the fruit of darkness, our senses encounter the world, which suddenly responds to us. But we forget. We lose everything down to the thread that would lead us back—down to the memory that it ever existed, within us. We build towers in order to protect ourselves against imaginary enemies without seeing that the apparatus is coiled inside of us, that the adversary is an inner principle whereby we are persecuted by ourselves better than any other could ever do.

Of a Perception Infinitely Vaster . . .

Is perception feeling and seeing at the same time? Perception reveals us to be plural, preventing us from coinciding exactly with the self-image that we carry around. Perceiving undoes us, dismantles thought, which never protects you as well as expected, each sensation just as legitimate as the judgment that contains it. It is impossible, I believe, to run the risk of perception without giving up a bit of our reason for being, of our sovereignty. In *The Waves*, Virginia Woolf returns us to a language that evokes the wonder and terror that inhabited us early in life, but on the basis of a pure sensation of the world. Novalis said it thus: "To every sensation man adds another sensation as soon as he begins to think." At the very end of World War Two, Merleau-Ponty echoes this thought: "In the present and in perception, my being and my consciousness are at one, not that my being is reducible to the knowledge I have of it or that it is clearly set out before me—on the contrary perception is opaque, for it brings into play, beneath what I know, my sensory fields which are my primitive alliance with the world—but because 'being conscious' is here nothing but 'being-to . . .' [*'être à . . .'*], and because my consciousness of existing merges into the actual gesture of 'ex-sistence.' It is by communicating with

the world that we communicate beyond all doubt with ourselves. We hold time in its entirety, and we are present to ourselves because we are present to the world."[1]

Our perception is much vaster than the boundaries of what we call "I." My body, my voice, the thoughts that visit me, the visions that traverse me, "it" in me that sees, breathes, and hears, feels more broadly than I do. If perception is carnal and makes itself visible to us, it is also, in part, what in us remains in a relation of immanence to the world. Paradoxically, the more we are a perceiving body, the less we are conscious of our singularity. What we are thereby given, from the specter of a perception so vast that it overflows consciousness on all sides, remains encrypted, registered down to the smallest detail. "It" in us that Freud one day decided to call the unconscious, remembers, recalls everything, for us, in our place. And we—like a dancer frozen in place—turn upon ourselves, wild eyed before the void, trying to stay upright like good little soldiers full of certainties. There are certain moments when bits of this pure perception occur in the interstices of consciousness and threaten us with imminent danger: the ego cannot confront this influx of perceptions undigested by consciousness that come from nowhere, from a region within us where we are *terra incognita*. Risk is a matter of opening up to this liberating amplitude. And of losing control. Of suffering where we seemed to be tranquil residents of our psychic space, because we often prefer consciousness of pain to the unknown.

There is a child, within you, who doesn't forget being held in such contempt, treated with such coldness, with such anxiety she was forced to confront all alone nights rife with ghosts (hers and others'), within the oblivion of the secret that enveloped her like a shroud. What have we preserved of this savage solitude to which we were consigned? Whom to trust? What can be done with these disordered words: commands, maledictions, promises, interdictions, deposited in us at random . . . What creative fervor will deliver them from our body, and at what price? Deposited within us there is a slight terror of the world spread like a film over the world to make it habitable. These words, then, translate the dread that the world is not in our hands. The greatest risk, we've known since always, is to love. To quit the enclosure, the belly of solitude, the haven of the familiar.

You might believe that you let yourself dream, be distracted, that you love being in love, and that you enjoy being alone, but no one would be duped . . . We doubt our own perception just as we doubt our desire. We are tyrannized by anxiety about not actualizing ourselves, by the fear of missing our life, as if "true" life was right there, ever so close, a meaningful existence just waiting for whoever knows how to grab hold and take full advantage of it. This doubt is our double, which persecutes us with a strange and insistent gentleness. To let ourselves be inundated by perception, by images from a perceptive capacity infinitely vaster than the ego, is to allow everything in us that records, comprehends, captures, hears, untangles, and intertwines, or that contains information about many generations and intelligence about multiple persons, of many genres, including animals, and doubtless vegetables as well, to think and to dream. Fine, then, but where is the risk? It is the risk of entering a penumbral domain, of apparent indistinction, of confusion among senses and genres, of what we sometimes attain through drunkenness and drugs and insomnia and being in love and in panic: a hyperlucidity that lifts the burden of one hundred thousand lives.

When he questions the Delphic oracle, Socrates obtains from her the maxim, *gnothi seauton* ("know thyself"). The "care of the self" to which she refers him is not a little egoistic apparatus but rather a capacity of being unto yourself that relies upon a perception that is inseparable from the intelligible. "Emotion does not say 'I,'" Deleuze writes. "It is very difficult to grasp an event, but I do not believe that this grasp implies the first person."[2] To understand what our perception is capable of, beyond the limits of mere subjectivity, always and once again we must deconstruct what we believed our self to be. Not to "become" yourself, but rather to go unto yourself like you go out in search of love. To construct white with light, to abandon childhood debts, the rigged dictates of the roles we assume, and the whole economy that wishes to put need in place of desire. To experience "the derangement of all the senses,"[3] as Rimbaud wrote. For whom is it their heart's joy to break the boundaries of perception at the risk of losing the boundaries of their own identity? To tarry with destruction, the abyss. The question of addiction comes up more insistently than ever. Dependence catches hold of us with the first breath our lungs take, with the tearing of the placenta, and fixates itself within us as a principle that is prolonged, whether we like it or not, in the search for substances, objects, bodies, sex, or ideals that are identified with life. "Expanded perception is the aim of art," Deleuze writes. "Such a goal can only be reached if perception breaks with the identity to which memory binds it . . . Extending perception means making forces that are ordinarily imperceptible sensible, resonant (or visible)."[4]

The experience of reanimation, Pierre Guyotat attests, is the traversal of a beyond, a terrifying echo chamber where the ego is dissolved, "as if each of your background thoughts was immediately echoed . . . it's terrible, you

are ripped apart, and when you get out of there, you are wretched, a little humanity still clings to you, but almost none . . ." Everything becomes both terribly carnal and obscene: "You feel like going away, you can no longer say 'I' and yet you must come back and start all over again . . . you have to plunge back in, into affect, while you inhabit a world that risks becoming pleasant, detached . . . impurity, that can only begin again, plus the fatigue . . . and you have already gone well down the road toward disappearance, after the big terrifying dreams calm sets in and 'they' would prefer that you be left in peace . . . And so this is what happened. Obviously, I love life even while I think it's unimportant . . . You'd like to be able to live, which is what drives everything, it is the absolute desire, the absolute in this world."[5] To come back from these territories between life and death that you might not have escaped alive—body shredded, mind lost, deep depressions, schizoid states, paralyses, and so on—is, as Guyotat bears witness, to experience the edge of the world where I am no longer "I," the edge of the self that is nothing but an open wound. Pure perception is not a simple state of presence but a region where there is no "person" to ensure a serene adequation with I, with self. Those who have explored this borderland between unbearable pain and the dissolution of everything that tethers them to life only rarely speak of their experience, and even when they do make themselves its witness it is only with an infinite modesty that could never be breached, imagining in their place what they lived through and whence they returned.

We are afraid of our own capacity to perceive, of the "visionary" in us, of what is commonly called intuition—that is, a knowledge you have in advance of yourself; a knowledge from which one prefers to deliver oneself even before it can be clearly formulated. Retroactively, our gestures, our dreams, our slips of the tongue, and our bungled actions reveal to us, like prophetic utterances, this capacity for intelligible perception much vaster than the ego. Artistic creation is always at grips with the apparatus out ahead of you that informs you, somehow unbeknownst to you, and that unfolds on the canvas, in the score, or on the page even before consciousness takes notice. Only upon rereading does it become aware.

Anxiety, Lack—Spiritual Hunger?

Anxiety is proper to man, a secret weapon without which humanity would founder. Is someone who is anxiety-free completely human? "How does spirit relate to itself and to its conditionality?" asks Kierkegaard.[1] "It relates to itself as anxiety. Do away with itself, the spirit cannot; lay hold of itself, it cannot, as long as it has itself outside itself. Nor can man sink down into the vegetative, for he is qualified as spirit; flee away from anxiety, he cannot, for he loves it; really love it, he cannot, for he flees from it . . . Here there is no knowledge of good and evil etc., but the whole actuality of knowledge projects itself in anxiety as the enormous nothing of ignorance."[2] And he adds: "Dreamily the spirit projects its own actuality, but this actuality is nothing, and innocence always sees this nothing outside itself."[3] Anxiety, the Danish philosopher recalls, is primarily a spiritual affliction. Throughout his work, he unceasingly explored the abysses of anxiety with the genius of his language and thought. He risked this exploration on the basis of his own history, beginning with the night when, as he recounts, his father cursed God. He didn't seek so much to understand anxiety as to describe its ordeal, without reducing or falsifying it, much less psychologizing it, which was already the rage in his epoch. The "nothing" that

he describes as innocence or ignorance enlarges the space of our spiritual hunger; for, such is anxiety, it speaks of an unquenchable desire, but also of our freedom. Anxiety does not always speak its own name, nor even that of despair. It is oppressive, clamps our hands around an imaginary support, causes migraines and vertigo, sparks intimations of an impending and ever deferred catastrophe. Mornings, it is a terrible malaise and the groundless expectation of some irreparable event. It takes place in our lives, in our sleepless nights, without ever unmasking the conflict that underlies it. This is the conflict that I call spiritual. Although spoken in the body, it will not be appeased unless the hunger that it combats is recognized as an aspiration that no substance could ever satisfy.

Anxiety is a smokescreen that spares consciousness the obligation to shed light on things it doesn't want to know anything about. The truth that anxiety shields us from, most often, is that of a combat raging totally unknown to us. To expose it requires that we distinguish between two orders of indefectible loyalties—that which stems from childhood experiences, from secrets and truncated genealogies, or from interdicted or unreachable memories of war and sacrificial silence; and that which beckons us to a freedom wholly cut off from any past. Anxiety is akin to a layer of snow atop a devastated landscape: everything, at first sight, is white, intact, almost unreal. Only with the thaw does the broken terrain emerge. Anxiety, like the snow, allows for nothing to be revealed, for all to remain enshrouded beneath the light anesthesia of the deadly cold. And yet an unease surges up, the stomach is tied in knots, the head swims, cruel and pointless insomnia sets in. Anxiety can't stop the conflict from spilling onto the territory of the body; it can only attempt to keep it unknown. You have no idea, at bottom, why you are reeling. The sense of failure, for instance, is not enough to explain why tears well up each time you try to say a word. Anxiety attacks the body to keep spirit afloat, to give enough strength to go on a bit further. Anxiety feeds on spirit, but our body is what it demands. Knotting the stomach or stealing our very breath, it churns gently from inside, never offering us any chance to regain life. Anxiety is an almost entirely immaterial hand-to-hand combat. The battlefield is psychic but the fighting is mainly physical. It extends the life of the living while leading them gently toward death.

Anxiety is the risk that none among us wishes to run, because it attacks the very meaning of what it is "to be." Spectral, it is a nocturnal visitor who prevents sleep. Witness to the conflict we wish to forget, it inheres in the memory of the event, of a childhood that we have surmounted by leaving part of ourselves behind as a hostage, at the mercy of an enemy unknown

to us. Thus it always requires its collateral. Anxiety reminds us that being alive does not come without a price. That the price is exorbitant—beyond all measure. That we will never have enough to pay it. And that perhaps we will always have to remain an other's debtor. Its action often deferred, anxiety never belongs to the time in which it operates (as in, for example, a panic attack); it comes from a previous time, perhaps even previous to your own existence; its rights hail from an other scene. A theater of shadows cast by light from an inaccessible source.

We are houses haunted by complaints that we have made our own, not knowing to whom they first belonged. What we are thus left with, of our own, is a raw, heart-rending complaint. And the daily stabbing pain of lack, which we attempt to float within reasonable limits. Depending on the circumstances, it might be a lack of love, of gentleness, of recognition, of money, of a child, of freedom, of pleasure, or all of them together in an excoriating mix. The sole witness to this lack is the child we once were. A child who demands reparations times a hundred, always for the same reason, at the same place, and becomes the adult's tyrant, her daily tormentor. We are haunted by the same thing as the child because her time does not pass. Never will pass again. This is the frozen time that Françoise Davoine and Jean-Max Gaudillière discuss so well in their magnificent book, *History Beyond Trauma*.[4] Even if this lack is ill-named, or displaced, it happens that analysis might welcome it. In this protected space, the adult in distress names her persecutors; analysis offers words for terror, frustration, anger, envy, or impotence; it opens a laborious path through the wicked forest. The phantom child is recognized; she agrees, for a time, to defect from the infernal economy of debt, its impossible settlement.

The path of spiritual freedom, Kierkegaard wrote, is repetition. How to tell this child that she will never obtain reparations, not full, perhaps not any? To disenchant the haunted house that we are in is not to pretend that nothing happened there, that there were not mass graves in the vicinity, that a secret hadn't been sealed between its four walls. Can the child within us accept this? How not to give up, but rather to help her give thanks for what is?

The melancholic, as Derrida reminds us,[5] is the one who refuses to forget. Against any reasons for appeasement and forgetting, against time's gradual healing of all wounds, the melancholic upholds her pain despite and against everything. Which impels Derrida to assert, "Melancholy is therefore *necessary*."[6] And thus it is necessary to make provision for all melancholy—to accept the incurable and thereby perhaps to welcome it as an unfillable void, suffering that cannot be alleviated, such that lack becomes

the very matter whereby desire is elevated, the place where life might relaunch, not just a seed of hope, but a movement that carries life forth. Welcoming lack thus protects the space of desire, its very restlessness. When the trauma that devastates psychic space allows for the upsurge of a lack, it already opens toward life, the touch of time and the very beginning of metamorphosis. To confront the possibility of radical loss is to change subjective position; it is not the same thing as staying strong or being resigned. Both lack and anxiety are forms of spiritual hunger. No experience of them spares us their negativity, or even their morbidity; but they can always become a vector of power also known as freedom.

Farewell Magic World: Beyond Disappointment

The world of childhood is a nacelle hanging in wait for something to happen . . . When everything is still possible. Disappointment is the stumble awaiting in each event and the mad hope that it sparks in us. The so-called adult world has yet to shut this Pandora's box. Disappointment, promise: it's as if neither exists without the other. You promised me love and you disappeared. Does life consist of anything but the succession of our defeats? The collapse of our hopes? Isn't disappointment ultimately a shadow theater, a make-believe world, the puppet strings that you discover tugging behind the gold-painted decor?

The experience of disappointment supposes having believed in a magic world, with fairy wands and dragons up in the sky and fantastic creatures everywhere you look. It is having played the game, having taken risks and in a certain respect having lost, but without regrets for having believed. If this world is not your dream come true, at least it contains your expectations and the promises I make to you. It used to be our shelter, our refuge and our freedom. And then it was shattered. Disappointment first belongs body and soul to childhood. Children are constantly disappointed and always find some way to regain hope—such valiant little soldiers! The

movement of expectation is what, *in spite of everything*, constitutes children in the very fiber of their being, because they are almost entirely, at every second, hope. They belong to the dreamworld far more that we realize. During the initial months of a child's life, the contours of the world are not yet directly real; they only become real little by little, very slowly. But, then, no parcel of everyday life escapes this world. Day and night her reveries will meet her with overheard and whispered words, even words kept secret, far away from her. Reverie, expectation, and what the child makes of our promises are the very matter of her body, her desire, and her gentleness. Adults cannot begin to imagine the amplitude of a child's disappointment, her capacity to be disappointed. Disappointment is a very gentle monster who swallows her up and spits her out into darkness, beyond the reach of sleep. A forgotten promise is enough to wreck an entire swath of her life, and no one notices. But right there amidst the wreckage of these ruins, she has already regained breath; she has begun to build a secret language, her refuge. This liability to disappointment is, paradoxically, an untapped reserve of imagination (a child cannot be broken, totally disappointed, without inflicting huge violence on her), which makes it possible for her to tame the real and to lodge herself in it; it is like a secret apparatus, her horizon of expectation.

Disappointment is the overturning of the magic world into the so-called real world; people say that it's the same world, but for oneself, it will never be the same—or it would be only if one were able to adopt the language of madness once and for all, and this would be too sad. To disappoint the other—lover, wife, child, friend—is to deceive expectations and attempt, afterward, to redeem yourself, in hope the bond remains intact. The one who disappoints would like to be forgiven for a transgression that doesn't exist because it rested on a promise. Unless the promise is more real than the real itself. To disappoint is to encroach on another person's dream in order to mine it with a miniscule time-bomb, in hope of still being loved after the conflagration—as if it was possible to forget speech and to begin over again.

One does not have the right to demand that a promise be kept; one can only hope it will be, by virtue of a primary ethics, because promising already entails a gamble on time, on the permanence of a subject who won't have sunken into madness or succumbed to death. But promising is also believing that you must abide by language and that the truth is at stake in everything said. Or not entirely in what is said but rather in the manner and moment at which it will have been said, in the intention of the body and the voice, in concentrated presence and the silence around it.

To disappoint is to have been disappointed during a savage, unremembered childhood. To have emerged from it supposes a great past experience of something hoped for and never renounced; to have traversed the collapse of the madness of childhood expectations—which doubtless passed unperceived—and survived. Nothing is more difficult to discern than disappointment; it is no more than the lightest flaking of paint on a wall, a mere hairline crack; and yet, it is a fall from which sometimes you don't recover. There are suicides that are appointments kept, forty years too late, in memory of a disappointment so slight, so subtle, that very few ears had perceived the shattering.

Life—Mine, Yours

What binds each of us to one another, and to risk, is our own lives. In fine, it is as language says: to risk your life. But where does the possessive pronoun, quietly slipped into this expression, come from? What does it mean to say "your" life—that is, your very own—and not simply "life"? What is the status of the possessive: *your*? To what extent is your life truly your own and what do you possess exactly when you say "my" life? In her very beautiful book on the La Borde clinic, Marie Depussé writes that possessive pronouns are all little ramparts that you erect in order to guard against the real, or desire, which are sometimes the same thing.[1] In any event, it is a matter of what tramples on the lovely order of our world, our trusty alibis, the memories we worship and those we pass over in silence, the edges of boundless shame and anxiety.

To speak of "risking your life" is to be alive in "your" own life and to envisage it as event that might be catastrophic or wonderful; that is, to envisage the possibility that death will come to bury life, cover it up, turn it away from itself or from yourself. It is a matter of risking the impersonality of a certain risk of what is most your own—that is, the possessive of "my" life; for, what else do I have in existence, in fact, except my life, because all

else can be taken away from me: beloved beings, objects, corporeity (or at least certain nonvital parts of my body that make my body not solely and entirely my life).

Nonetheless, this risk isn't entirely subjective, or personal, or even voluntary; it is that by which we constantly exceed ourselves. It is that in which we are lost and exchange the feeling of irremediable loss for the desire to remain on the move in territories where it's possible to explore desire. How do we lose what is not ours? Life is given to us, this much we can admit whether or not we are believers. And yet it's scarcely ours, this life, which is the last thing that properly belongs to us, the last event that we live, and the last solitude that we experience, and also our place of greatest hope. There, perhaps, is this layer of intense life, bound up with the dead along with the memory and history of those who will never possess the words to transmit it. There, perhaps, lies the risk of "your" life—the fact that it is absolutely singular and yet not your own . . . Like any crushing experience, this life does not belong to us and yet we alone have lived it and have been transformed by it. We are transformed enough that, after the fact, in the future anterior, we can judge that life will have been risked up to that point, perhaps, in us; that this hospitality, like that of madness, or amorous delirium, was a violence that we ended up surviving, for good or for ill, and returned from; that it will have been life that thus risked us—against death and with it, against attachments, loyalties, defenses, families, shame, and the burial of all memory; because at this very instant we have been *passeurs*, most often unconsciously—that is, in an incandescence, a sadness, a dependence, a revolt, an imagination, a love, or a silence that remains unknown to us and yet found asylum within us. To say, "I risk my life," is almost impossible. Only at rare moments do we coincide with ourselves to such an extent. But we must believe it possible to say: life was risked in him or her—that is, as a witness, to recognize this risk in a painful fraternity, perhaps, but a true one.

At the Risk of the Unknown

At the risk of asking a woman to get up and dance and whispering to her: "Close your eyes."

At the risk of taking the car into the city for dinner and ending up in Rome the next day after driving through the night, just because you changed your mind.

At the risk of seeing your husband wave off the little Pakistani seller of (crumpled) roses for the fiftieth time and you buying his whole armful and offering them to everyone in the room.

At the risk of sleepless nights.

At the risk of writing a letter to an unknown man or woman just because of a slight feeling that coursed through you with an intensity you never knew before.

At the risk of making love over and over.

At the risk of praying without the help of any God, or even with it.

At the risk of hidden, mad, hopeless, infinite friendship. Worse than love.

At the risk of boredom, and loving this boredom without recourse.

At the risk of walking alone in a city and expecting at any instant to happen on the whole meaning of life, knowing that tomorrow it will be gone again.

At the risk of listening to Bach's *Saint Matthew Passion* on repeat.

At the risk of assuming all of someone else's responsibilities, without taking the slightest precaution.

At the risk of gathering pebbles of glass polished by the sea and then, the same evening, scattering them on the beach.

At the risk of a communism of thought.

At the risk of joy.

At the Risk of Being Carnal

He watches as the body of the dancer rises into the air and asks himself: "What is your secret?"

—ALAIN DIDIER-WEILL, *Lila et la lumière de Vermeer*

To have a body, to be a body, to take bodily form . . . How do we navigate among these three locutions? Having a body supposes that it might be possible that we don't have one, that the body is a place where we never fully are. Being a body identifies us with this animate matter that we call a body but still remains hardly namable, especially given that the body is also the emotions that traverse it, the ideas that affect it, the unquantifiable pain that shatters it, or the fulgurant jouissance that infuses it. "No one knows what a body can do," wrote Spinoza. Where does a body, or the capacity of a body, begin and where does it stop? In what sense is my identity entirely captured within this so-called carnal envelope? Does embodiment designate the act whereby we make the body we have into the body we are? Does taking bodily form mean entering your body just as having is transmuted into being, the thing into essence, or the object into subject? Being carnal is at one and the same time having, being, and taking bodily form . . .

In jouissance, you lose your body in an ordeal of a joy whereby you are at once delivered and incarnated—*embodied* is the word in English. Antonio Damasio says that the body is contained in the soul and not the reverse. The body itself is traversed through and through by something that infi-

nitely exceeds it, that opens it, that exposes it to the unlimited. In song, the human voice is both the most material and the most immaterial thing—*das Ding*, the "thing" itself, Lacan would say. What it gives us to hear is a plane of immanence in the body that is infinitely vaster than what is perceptible, palpable, or visible. The voice gestures toward something in which we were bathed as children, something that most definitely constituted us as far back as the embryo's first cellular divisions—that is, the amniotic sound carrying with it the maternal voice, but also the voices of the father and siblings, as well as the sonorities that become the agents of love and hate, repulsion, attachment, and disgust, sonorities ceaselessly adjoined with food (from the umbilical cord), the movements inside the mother's body (felt by the fetus), and audition. This passage between the inside and the outside is constantly assured and reassuring, ushering in the whole of the possible, the burgeoning space of a subject to come. Our carnal being is an entity that goes infinitely beyond the perceptible body; it must be adjoined by the thought body, the imagined body, the dreamed body, the body of the voice, the body of taste, the affected body, or the body overtaken by fever, jouissance, drunkenness, the body that migrates beyond the body in order not to suffer, for example. Descartes will remain the father of Cartesianism—that is, the consummate divorce between the thinking subject and extended space—and yet, for his whole life his first question will have been what constitutes the union of the soul and the body, and how can this union even be thought. Biologists today seek answers just as urgently to the same question.

To be a body, to have a body, is also to be nude. What a strange risk nudity is. With age you forgive your body for not being perfect; you sometimes reconcile with it when it begins to slip away from you. Nudity is always scandalous because it lets be seen what cannot be seen; it offers what precisely cannot be offered; it supposes a sharing, delimits a territory open to sight and touch when, in reality, it has no extension, remains out of reach. Nudity can be photographed, delimited, and constrained; it can be caressed, avoided, and hidden, but what it offers cannot be taken. This is certainly the reason why it is so arousing: covetousness, hatred, desire, horror, compassion, the wish to remove every last veil. "Bodies (and souls) are forces. As such they are defined by their chance encounters and collisions (state of crisis). They are defined by relationships between an infinite number of parts that compose each body and that already characterize it as a 'multitude.'"[1]

What does it mean to risk nudity, today, when it is offered up everywhere all the time, on every possible platform, retouched and not? The risk

of nudity is the unveiling of intimacy, an unmapped territory that separates me from another body with whom I am not (yet) one, before whom I create a space that is not simply that of my proper body. This is the space of my body from which, in a certain sense, my nudity is split off. This unreachable nudity is what's proper to the soul, a word that Freud himself used all the time, which people don't realize enough, because it tends to be translated as "psychic apparatus." This soul he envisaged has no other surface than the body, its essential nudity. Nudity, like a Moebius strip that makes it impossible to distinguish inside from outside, is also a metaphor. The words you employ to qualify it, whereby you adorn it, or spoil it, or avoid speaking it, naming it, or detailing it, will end up speaking of you, of your most secret intimacy, of your own history, and of history as such, of your fears, of you as a little child, and of you as a future little old person or victim of unfortunate events, of you at the place where your name gives way to this skin that bodies forth, that becomes a loving body, a tearful body, or a combatant body. There is no demarcation and no sign that allows you to say: here is the dead center of interiority, there where you cannot gain access, the place where spirit resides apart from all flesh. No, there is no such retreat, precisely because everything is there; out in the intangible space of nudity, it remains forever unreachable, and even in a certain sense invisible. There is a drive to expose things that keep silent, that are so open to being seen that they cannot be seen, by a rhetorical sleight of hand, precisely because nudity continually outstrips the gaze, touch, and sensation. "But what is caressed is not touched, properly speaking. It is not the softness or warmth of the hand given in contact that the caress seeks. The seeking of the caress constitutes its essence by the fact that the caress does not know what it seeks. This 'not knowing,' this fundamental disorder, is the essential. It is like a game with something slipping away, a game absolutely without project or plan, not with what can become ours or us, but with something other, always other, always inaccessible, and always still to come. The caress is the anticipation of this pure future, without content."[2]

She couldn't stand being seen nude. No more than she could looking at her face. It seemed to her that between them—nudity, face—there was an indissoluble pact, a secret kinship. I asked whether she remembered a particular scene from her childhood or adolescence in which her image might be present. She thought for a long time. Nothing in particular emerged but the memory of uncontrollably laughing with her sisters in bed at undressing time; nothing more. But yesterday she did recall an apparently banal scene that featured an image of her nude. It was summertime, very hot, and everyone was bathing in the river next to their property. Far from any onlookers, or so it seemed, she dove into the water and—

seven or eight years old at the time—delighted in being nude. Once back on shore, she looked in vain for her clothes. And yet, everyone else was gone. She ran across the open field back to the house, not very far, and up to her room to get dressed. None of her cousins or her sisters were there, all gone to play badminton; she had been the only one who decided to stay longer at the river, which is why she went nude. She joined the others and no one made the slightest allusion to the event. She also didn't talk about it that evening and never knew who took her clothes. Never knew whether anyone had seen. Her. Nude.

I listened attentively to her—that is, with a certain astonishment.

"Could it be that I took this theft [vol] *to be a rape* [viol]*?" she asked. "The culprit was most likely someone close to me, I mean it must have been because a stranger would have had to cut across the lawn in front of the house, continue into the woods behind it, onto private, unknown property. But no one was there except my cousins, just silly adolescents and their parents, and another couple who were my parents' friends." She paused for a moment. "It actually could be them, but why? Why play such a nasty trick on a little girl bathing in the river? To punish me, to embarrass me? If so, I would have known, they would have ended up telling me . . . I need for you not to leave me alone with this. I don't understand . . . Would it have been enough to double-lock me in this impossible gaze upon myself, I mean to lock me in outside. I don't understand . . ."*

"And what if this scene never took place?"

"Why would you say that? Don't you believe me?"

"Yes, I believe you. But perhaps you lost track of your clothes, for example, because you drifted a bit downstream, with the current? And you might have interpreted their disappearance how you did, as the prefiguration of what you call a 'rape' of your intimacy. This is what we do with our memories, lending them something of a prophetic value."

"For what reason?"

"The river, in dreams, is sometimes an extension of the maternal body, the uterine body . . ."

"This would then be a way of staging the rape of an image, of imagining that someone, if I denuded myself, would come steal my protection, my armor?"

I allowed for a silence. Then I continued: "Perhaps . . . memories are auguries. We place them at the beginning and then return to them because they tell something about what we have become; they are not completely made up, but we do unconsciously sift them, transform them, or mishandle them so that they become shards of a mirror reflecting our future ego, our existence to come."

"It's dizzying."

Nudity is a violence; it exposes us to the gaze, or a caress, or blows, or contempt, or seduction, without an opposing shore to lean on. The river is a state of liquid

fusion where, in the uterine body regained, there is nothing but the pure nudity of being. Do the stolen clothes [habits dérobés] *mark the impossibility of being "one," of confidently letting oneself go? Perhaps this memory itself—whether true or reconstituted—steals* [dérobe] *from consciousness a more ancient theft* [vol], *a more archaic ripping away, itself outside any possibility of representation. This is what I gestured toward in my words to her. Doubt—which is to say, the vertigo that gripped the adult dreamer, lying there on the couch and in the impossibility that she betrays of confronting her own image, her nudity—thus arises as an effraction within the defensive citadel of forgetting. What is repressed, perhaps, far from this river, is the very earliest body.*

In amorous fusion you hardly feel the other's nudity or your own—by which I mean that these nudities form a third body that is the body of desire. In neurosis, nudity is altered—spoiled. It can be subjugated, confiscated, dismantled, and destroyed like we have perhaps been destroyed or abandoned. This is why the road is so long perhaps before you are able to abandon yourself to it with confidence, with friendship.

May There Be an End to Our Torment . . .

What do we want from an analyst: an end to our torments, a meaning to life, an answer for our fears, help finding love at last? Sometimes you have no idea what to hope for; you only know that someone will be there to listen. Perhaps that is all . . . an ear. There will be a framework posited, for protection: that is, a meeting place and one or two moments during the week apart from the daily routine, for a few months or a few years. It's also expensive for what you get: less than an hour. How can you believe that this would suffice to lift impediments to living? By what miracle will speech be able to conjure a whole generation of silence and misunderstandings? How can it dispel maledictions, despair, rage, mad jealousy, insomnia, amorous fever, or mourning? How much do you ask of a cure that you no longer even dare not believe in, even when you go ahead and entrust yourself to it, almost despite yourself? What will you lose in the process, and what might you discover along the way? In a strange way, they are the same thing: what you lose, what you find, but wholly otherwise. And how it happens is through the almost alchemical transmutation of a language. More than a language, in fact, it is a strange address, a living metaphor. Heard speech calls the analyst to witness as the one to whom it is addressed

in secret. Whether silent or spoken aloud, whether a plea to a lover, the absent one, a reproach to a dead person, an incantation toward an animal, or a god, or the memory of a beloved body . . . this address makes language into a living, animate, or quasi-magic thing whose phenomenal power comes from the fact that it traverses at once the body and the spirit, and that it is linked, by breath, to the fact of arriving in life because an other carried you, named you, prattled to you, hoped for you, dreaded you, sung to you, and delivered you—what is called *being born*.

This speech is the space of our humanity, of hospitality to a humanity that, insofar as it is a space of immanence, absolutely overflows our subjectivity. In the voyage into and through this speech, therefore, a strange transmutation takes place that we have called: losing, then finding, and not re-finding, because what's found is a real find, in the sense of something singular, unprecedented, an unhoped for encounter, an overturning, almost a conversion without religion or armature, a pure event. Lacan said it somewhat differently: "How do we recognize one who loves? He has changed discourse." The word "discourse" should be understood in the Greek sense as logos, which has a secret affinity with truth.

Is the patient the only one who loses something in the senseless enterprise of analysis or does the analyst also lose something? At the beginning of an analytic cure, the subject interrogates her history; she explores the hidden byways of this history—its impasses, its secrets; slowly and against the grain she treads back to a past that she believes herself to know in part, pieces together the puzzle, assembles things said, convokes her memories and her buried emotions. She becomes an explorer and, in this excavation, exhumes treasures, vestiges, as well as horrors. She draws connections, forges hypotheses, and begins to detach affects from one another, to untangle fears, to isolate the different parts of her history (parents, siblings, friends, enemies), and in this enormous site, she does the work of reconnaissance; like an archeologist, she classifies, sifts, and exhumes. In this first period of analysis, she identifies guilty parties, those whom she knows and those whom she has misjudged; she will identify harm done, injuries. And naming them, she dresses (and addresses) them, disinfects the dormant wound that contaminated her whole psyche. We are still in a kind of refuge, a place where the work of analysis discovers unusual clearings; and yet, there is as yet no question what she, the patient, has invested in the subtle and permanent interplay between others and herself. This is when the true loss occurs. Little by little, what seemed to be solid ground will crumble; security will give way to doubt and vertigo.

The gambler's greatest fear, which buoys and saves her, is losing. To risk losing is to hold out hope of winning, of being able to make yet another bet, waiting, kept in suspense for an instant as the tiny ball hops around, as the next card peels from the deck, deciding her fate. To risk losing is to forge into the silky black of the shadows, in the belief that all will not close in on you, in the hope that something will reappear, unfold, bend back. Something that was not completely unknown to you . . . But what you lose in analysis, perhaps, is not simply the meaning that you believed it possible to give things; it is the "why," the imaginary cause of your complaint, of your affection, and of the injustice that accounts for it. It is the certainty that this is what has always determined your life. There is no why. Both consciousness and its inscription within the world are bound up and composed with the possibilities of the world. The delicate layering of the multiple events and determinations that produce the real are mixed up with your history, with endless ramifications, well beyond what's perceptible. And so what gets lost, at a given moment, is the certainty of belonging to a world, a language, or a territory of immediately transmissible recognition.

You are the patient who begins to lose your grip and no longer even knows why you came in the first place . . . The lack you used to feel so deeply—a lost lover, the child you didn't have, fleeting beauty, the time of youth, past glory—no longer affects you in the same way; you are prising yourself away from things you used to consider the most precious, your life's safeguards. But another lack will now appear, another sort of lack, such a radical lack in being that it will displace every other lack; it is a spiritual lack, a void that attracts and increases, that allows for linkage and life.

Breaking Up

Is this one of life's indispensable events: breaking up? But what a bizarre idea . . . For example, you'll probably agree that, most of the time, people don't enter analysis for the purpose of breaking up with someone but rather to heal after a break up. After a bereavement, a bout of melancholia, or a divorce perhaps, they come to repair themselves, to air their grievances. Nonetheless, what if analysis were a school of rupture?

Breaking up is oh so tedious, always the same old story. Nothing is sadder, today, than a breakup. Chronicles of unlove foretold, they seal the demise of an attraction that fell apart before it had a chance to develop. Pointless emotional burdens, vulgar feelings of despair, vague death wishes, the ingredients are always, or almost always, the same. In the case of a couple, the children become helpless onlookers of the carnage, forced to bear witness to a story that began well before they came on the scene and already wrapped up, digested in a necrology hastily composed for judges tired of listening to the same quarrels. There is a generalized lassitude about breakups because no one has a choice in the matter, as if the only thing we know how to do marginally well is break up. Or threaten to . . . and then do it anyway in a bout of unescapable melancholy. The thresholds of tolerance

have been displaced, especially among women, whereas men are disoriented . . . To all appearances, breaking up has become a matter of style. Because it's bound to happen, the only question is—when? And then—how? After things get back to normal, it's like nothing happened. Life goes on, they say. But breaking up remains a rather grave thing to do, perhaps because no one really takes the risk of breaking up for real. We let breaking up act upon us like an ill wind of revolt, a "too late" converted into a now, a flurry of sad thoughts that end up gently laying waste to everyday life, nothing left unscathed. But, in the end, is that all it takes? Because we don't have much idea what we're looking for. New freedom? You've got to be naïve. Revenge, perhaps? The satisfaction fades so soon. Maybe, then, it's that you wanted an end to incomprehension, boredom, fatigue, recriminations. All of it, yes, no question, and yet a breakup happens between beings without really changing them; it wafts over them, undoes bonds, exhausts past hopes, and creates new and unanticipated obligations, all of it rather outside of oneself, as if, in the end, it happened out of bounds.

Nonetheless, I maintain that we must take the risk of breaking up. At least once. This is something you encounter in analysis, without knowing it. Breaking up, not with he or she whom we claim to love, or to hate, but rather with the more deep-seated pact whereby we are beholden to a debt older than our very lives, a debt that makes us inherently *obligated beings*. Why are we willing to pay such an exorbitant price to recommence the same scenario over and over again? Why do we prefer to hold on to our poor little miseries in place of the joy that might arise from the unknown, from the open sea? What keeps us here on the opaque side of things, closed off from memory, as close as possible to the regions where we suffered abandonment and lack? Still, we must—always and again—save our childhood from disaster, as if it behooved us to rescue it from an imminent shipwreck, sometimes fifty years after the fact. But what is the truth that frightens us so much as we shift the pieces around the chess board until all players are exhausted? "We believe that some novelty in our lives will turn everything upside down, make us unrecognizable, and enliven fossils; but we soon realize that what actually fascinates us about the new is the element of déjà-vu that it harbors," writes Maurice Terence. The same pieces along the same diagonals, from breakup to breakup, the same game is played again and again.

He left her before the summer. Like a dog left by the roadside. Just a note stuck to the fridge (the fridge!): I can't anymore. She had gone to her dance class, bought flowers for once, and arrived home in a carefree mood. They had lived together for a little less than a year. A perfect bliss, as it were. No intimation of disaster. Now

she had to play the whole film in reverse. What's the meaning of this? She puts the flowers down, unfolds the red tissue paper . . . "I can't anymore." She has a fit of mad laughter and then collapses in tears. Hours pass. No sign of him. When the day finally turns to night, she has lost the ability to think. Nothing, there is nothing in her head. It's empty, as if no one had ever been there, ever. Nothing has any weight anymore. All is fuzzy. No hunger or cold has she now. No body.

At the hospital, they ask her name. She's at pains to remember. Finally, she pronounces it, very slowly, as if making sure it's right. The doctor is young, the psychiatrist on call one Sunday. He had anticipated harrowing emergencies, feared that the day of rest is particularly hard to bear for those who are locked out in their nausea and their dread. But he was not afraid of this frail woman. On the contrary, he felt like taking her in his arms and speaking gentle words to her. He can't. What happened to you? She said nothing, and so he began to speak, a bit at random, of himself, his likes and dislikes. And little by little she regained her color, in front of his very eyes. She took root and came to life like the plants in E.T., *a movie that he would watch on Sunday afternoons as a child, a memory that couldn't but make him smile.*

"Who brought me here?" she finally asked.

"You don't remember?"

"Your sister. You called her for help."

"Where is she now?"

"Home. She said that she couldn't leave her children alone. But she'll be back tomorrow. She signed the papers so you can rest. Do you know why you were brought here?"

He doesn't know whether he's allowed to say this. But he says it.

"My boyfriend left me," she responds. "That's not so serious," she adds, watching him. "Right?"

How to answer? At this moment, what's his role? He no longer knows. Should he tell her the truth? But what truth? That she was brought here because she became delusional. That her sister wanted to unload her as quickly as possible. That he is just the intern on call; that this is his first emergency; and that he no longer understands much of anything. Except perhaps her suffering. The biggest fear in this place is that the lovelorn will attempt suicide. We can't take that risk, they would answer (he knows already) if he requested same-day release for her (which makes her a prisoner?). She will have to be medicated and show that her wits have returned. In our day, it is scandalous to love too much. We are entreated to love within the limits of reason alone.

She slept. She stayed for a few days and then went home. There was mail at her door. But from him, nothing. She thought it was better that way. It seemed that she had the body of a newborn who barely knew how to breathe or to move,

that she would have to relearn everything, slowly. She often thought of the intern: he probably didn't know that he saved her with his small talk, his awkward patience, and all the time for nothing that he devoted to her that Sunday night. She who loathed hospitals, crybabies, and Sundays . . . Under other circumstances, she might have fallen in love with him, but now she would always think of him as the young doctor too young for the task at hand, a little perplexed, lost amidst his too weighty function, and yet . . . To learn to break up, for this woman, would mean to accept the unthinkable, to proceed as if she'd taken a new name, opened herself to another gaze, and to reinvent everything.

The risk of breaking up, truly, for once, we have all actually taken it, at birth. When we breathe outside the womb for the first time, when new air fills our lungs and makes us cry, and we enter the world. Why should we have to be born anew? Why isn't one time enough? The risk of breaking up is the risk of revolution in the stellar sense of the term—*revolverer*, to turn around an axis. Such revolt isn't without wounds, but it is sovereign.

At the Risk of Speech

> We truly incline toward something only when it in turn inclines toward us, toward our essential being, by appealing to our essential being as what holds us there. Through this inclination, our being is called forth. Inclination is address. This address speaks to us from our essential being, calls us into being and holds us there.
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> What keeps us in our essential being holds us only so long, however, as we for our part keep holding on to what holds us.
>
> —MARTIN HEIDEGGER, "What Calls for Thinking"[1]

Speaking and keeping silent, throughout the history of humanity, have always been two paradoxical figures of our liberation, our salvation, as well as our loss, and our night. Can I gently take my turn to speak? Can I speak without *taking* a turn? Without violence, without abuse? Instead, the question would be: can speech coexist amicably, fraternally, with me, with us? Very quickly, very soon, the exercise of speech becomes an exercise of power. From childhood on, obviously. The cry, in this sense, is what comes before speech. The cry—that of the child still an *infans*, or that of the prophet—is an impatience, a desire for speech. The cry shatters the voice without words. The will to speak is heard as early as the cry, as early as the first call. Speech gives form to the call, to the voice, to desire, to our engagement within existence. Confession is primarily avowal because it is the act of abandonment through speech to the Word. From Socrates to Augustine and up to Freud there is a continuous revolution that makes the given or avowed word—in brief, inner space—into the place of the truth of being. Its testing ground.

In analysis, it sometimes happens that speech in its entirety comes to

grief, gets lost. There are those who make it to analysis only to have speech fail them, those to whom this act is refused, denied. Whose speech has been trampled on. Those who are frightened of speech, encumbered by it, or from whom it escapes. There exist lives that speech devastates, that this act of will and power overturns, and often kills. Are we healers of speech? Can we, in the cradle of analysis, through its slow anamnesis, rediscover a primary complicity with the world that would found each subject's ability to speak of it, to speak it, to say the world? This will to speak is often lacking. The will to hold to the world through speech. We are all plunged in a sort of insomnia that fixates speech within an impossible silence—the patient no less than the analyst. And slowly we begin to stammer, we *are at a loss for words* (another strange expression, abusive, because words are never first ours to lose but always the words of others, or other words, spoken by those who were here before us . . .) but we hang onto the heroic conviction that words will save us if we can just find them. As if our world owed its presence to nothing but a few words pronounced in the dark.

In analysis, we come across phantoms but also old people lost in speech as in a fantastic, black, and frightening world, populated by words without things, faces without names, words without head or tail. A father or a mother whom language drives mad, whom speech has drowned in the world. And those who persuade us, on certain days of distress, when speech no longer passes between them and us, that a great outbreak of Alzheimer's disease lies at the root of all possible humanity: I speak and nothing is created. I create, I make, and nothing is spoken, nothing is said. No longer spoken, life is savage, anterior, overwhelming. Speech becomes like a nocturnal calque on life and its horror. What is lost when speech dies? What can be regained? Is it something that we remember like an ancient event, a lost scent, or a person both alive and dead? Do there exist memories that will never have belonged to spoken life?

"The created world is everything that we can remember through speech," writes Frédéric Boyer. What analysis says is that the simple fact of being alive, of existing and speaking, of naming the world, is endowed with an inexhaustible value for life. It opens an immense freedom for us between life and death. The act of speech is also political: it is invested with a power, a gravity, and a sovereignty that make speech itself a indispensable to existence and power. "It is only our words which bind us together and make us human," writes Montaigne.[2] Often we think that we don't know, that the origins escape us . . . However, the beginning lies in the act of seizing the moment to speak that consists of saying the world, naming it. This

is what is lost and what is regained. The same speech, but now returned. Lost in the process is the fantasy of an origin. The created world is never a stranger to us so long as we speak.

Speech is caught up in this analytic grinder: speaking in order to create, speaking to make happen, and speaking to recognize the thing created. The grinder that cycles between creation and recognition, between beginning and memory. Certain people can't recognize anything that their own speech has created, anything that the speech around them creates, does or undoes. There is a negative creation or a negative of creation, when speech no longer recognizes either things or words. When it no longer serves to make the world familiar but rather unsettles us like an other side of the world or an *other* of the world. Can speech also destroy the world? Or rather can the world destroy speech? I desire to speak in order to be because speech itself is the desire to be welcomed.

Words come afterwards. After the intimate and overwhelming certainty of the event, after the real, after birth, after death itself, words always lag behind; always, after the fact, they attempt to explain what can't be explained, to give meaning to what causes nothing but vertigo; they reformulate memories, imprint them with tranquil assurance when they are as evanescent, as troubling, and as new as the very words that retrace them—everything is reinvented, which is what's incredible. No one can recreate the tonality or immense emotional charge of the first music from before our birth. The first vocal tonality remains unavowed, unavowable. Words register our alibis, our requirement that things be a certain way, our need for meaning, fidelity, sharing, our belief that we speak the same language, that words alone might change something; and it's true that, if they have such power, it derives from the primary, definitive emotion that binds them to our body. Our thinking, hoping bodies, our distraught and sobbing bodies as well, free, at times, of words.

Solitudes

There is no solitude if it does not disrupt solitude, the
better to expose the solitary to the multiple outside.

—MAURICE BLANCHOT, *The Infinite Conversation*

Is solitude a secret prefiguration of death? We can accept solitude in small doses, for a limited time, when the other remains within reach and we tremble at the thought of losing her; we play with the idea, frighten ourselves, feel alone, and then cry. But solitude as the space of the world is something other, wholly other. When the known world disappears, when its contours start to fade, when you keep heading down the same endless corridors without knowing where your steps will lead, when the darkness no longer promises light, when no voices seem familiar anymore, when nothing echoes but your own weightless movements above the void, where does one find refuge? Who will hear us, who recognize us? Solitude is sometimes the name for this opacity, for this slow panic that comes over the whole body to the point of paralysis, when you no longer even know the name of love. Here, who knows, there might appear another moment of the world, another name for the real.

In chosen solitude, which comes with joy and lightness of being, nostalgia for what used to be disappears, along with regret for what never happened, and the burden of all repetitions gathered up in the blink of an eye. It is the movement of this yes, to life, to the instant, the child's